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Editor's Note



AIR INDIA FLIGHT CRASH: A WAKE-UP CALL FOR AIR TRAVEL SAFETY

The recent Air India flight crash has once again brought aviation safety into the spotlight, reminding the world of the critical importance of stringent safety standards in air travel. While the aviation industry remains one of the safest modes of transportation globally, accidents, though rare, can have devastating consequences.

The tragic Air India crash serves as a painful reminder that even in an age of advanced aviation technology, safety cannot be taken for granted. Every air accident offers lessons that must be carefully studied to prevent similar tragedies in the future.

Stringent Aircraft Maintenance, Advanced Pilot Training, Modern Technology, and Airport Infrastructure are the Key Safety Measures in Air Travel. Continuous simulator-based training helps pilots respond effectively to emergencies, bad weather, and technical failures. Regular inspections, checks, and upgrades ensure aircraft meet global safety standards. Advanced avionics, terrain warning systems, and real-time weather updates improve flight planning and mid-air decision-making.

Importantly, regulatory bodies like the DGCA in India and international agencies like the ICAO must remain vigilant and proactive. Their oversight is essential in monitoring airline compliance with global safety protocols and ensuring corrective actions are implemented. Policies must be constantly reviewed and updated to match evolving threats and challenges in aviation.

The Air India incident, involving a flight that tragically crashed during landing amid adverse weather conditions, resulted in multiple fatalities and injuries. Initial reports suggest a combination of poor visibility, challenging terrain, and possible lapses in operational decision-making contributed to the crash.

A thorough investigation is underway by the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), alongside independent aviation experts, to determine the exact cause and ensure accountability.

Air India flight crash underscores the necessity of continual improvement in aviation safety. Over the years, international aviation authorities and airlines have made tremendous strides in reducing accident rates through technological advancements, pilot training programs, and enhanced maintenance protocols. However, as this incident shows, there is no room for complacency.

While investigations into the Air India crash continue, the focus must remain on learning from this tragedy. Enhancing pilot training, updating older aircraft, improving airport safety infrastructure, and strict enforcement of regulations are all essential to preventing future mishaps.

As the nation mourns the loss of innocent lives, the aviation industry must channel this grief into resolve. Safety is not just a one-time checklist - it is an ongoing journey of improvement. The systems, procedures, and attitudes around aviation must evolve with every incident.

Every aviation disaster brings sorrow, but it must also bring change. Each incident is a stark reminder that safety is a journey, not a destination. By embracing these lessons and taking action at every level, from policy to cockpit, India and the global aviation industry can work towards safer skies for all.

The skies must not just be friendly - they must be uncompromisingly safe. Let this be a turning point, not just a headline. Let it be a pledge - to protect every passenger, every crew member, and the future of Indian aviation.

Rajani A
Editor



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SHAIKHA AL NOWAIS NOMINATED AS FIRST WOMAN SECRETARY- GENERAL OF UN TOURISM

The Council's election of Shaikha Al Nowais as the next Secretary-General, with her term set to begin in January 2026, marks a pivotal moment

In a historic move, an accomplished business leader and Corporate Vice President at Rotana Hotels from UAE, Ms. Shaikha Nasser Al Nowais, has

been nominated to serve as the next Secretary-General of UN Tourism, poised to become the first woman to hold the prestigious position in the organization's 50-year history. Her nomination, pending confirmation by the UN Tourism General Assembly, was announced during the 123rd session of the Executive Council, which convened to review progress and chart the future of global tourism.

The Executive Council meeting underscored the sector's robust recovery, with the May 2025 World Tourism Barometer reporting over 300 million international tourist arrivals in the first three months of 2025. This figure represents an increase of approximately 14 million compared to the same period in 2024, highlighting strong global travel demand. Member States received updates on initiatives aimed at building a more innovative, resilient, and sustainable tourism sector.

Secretary-General Zurab Pololikashvili reflected on his tenure, stating, "Over the last eight years, UN Tourism has embraced a transformative vision. We have put tourism at the forefront of the global agenda to enhance its competitiveness and economic value. And we have never lost sight of our key priorities: education, investments,

sustainable and rural development, women empowerment, new technologies, and international expansion."

A Landmark Nomination for the Sector

The Council's election of Shaikha Al Nowais as the next Secretary-General, with her term set to begin in January 2026, marks a pivotal moment. Her nomination represents a landmark first for the sector, signifying a significant step forward for gender representation in global tourism leadership.

Shaikha Nasser Al Nowais is an accomplished Emirati business leader with over 16 years of experience in the global hospitality industry. As Corporate Vice President at Rotana Hotels, she has overseen owner relations across the Middle East, Africa, Eastern Europe, and Turkey. A finance graduate from Zayed University, she also chairs the Abu Dhabi Chamber's Tourism Working Group and holds board positions on the Abu Dhabi Businesswomen Council and the Les Roches Hospitality Academy.

This nomination signals a continued commitment to the priorities of innovation, investments, and education, building upon the strong legacy established over the past eight years and setting a new trajectory for UN Tourism under pioneering leadership.



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UN TOURISM & SLOW FOOD PARTNER TO STRENGTHEN TOURISM & AGRICULTURE

**Links to benefit of destinations and communities;
work together to promote gastronomy tourism as a tool for
socio-economic development of people and communities**





the vital role responsible, inclusive tourism can play in supporting communities everywhere. The work of Slow Food is fully aligned with UN Tourism values and we trust this partnership will play an important role in advancing the development of a sustainable gastronomy tourism that leaves no one behind, for the benefit of communities and destinations”.

Slow Food Director General Paolo Di Croce added: “Tourism can be a powerful force for strengthening sustainable local food systems. Our Slow Food Travel program is a sustainable culinary tourism initiative designed to create immersive travel experiences that support rural communities and celebrate local gastronomic heritage. In line with our values, it offers a unique opportunity to connect with farmers and producers around the world, while discovering and tasting the rich, often overlooked biodiversity of food.”

This partnership marks an important step towards enhancing the relationship between two industries with significant potential to join forces for sustainable regional and local development, strengthening local food systems, safeguarding culinary heritage, empowering women, youth and local communities, and promoting the consumption of healthy foods.

In a new Memorandum of Understanding signed on the occasion of Sustainable Gastronomy Day, both organizations commit to strengthening the gastronomy tourism value chain, enhancing the linkages between food producers, tourism service providers, destinations, communities and tourists. They will focus particularly on the development of value added, and innovative tourism experiences linked to local products, sustainable food systems, inclusivity and rural development.

Areas of collaboration will include research on trends in gastronomy tourism; identifying and sharing of case studies and best practices; training and skills development; as well as the creation of networks in gastronomy tourism, enhancing relationships between food producers and tourism stakeholders.

UN Tourism Secretary-General Zurab Pololikashvili says, “UN Tourism recognizes



INDIA'S

INTERNATIONAL VISITOR SPEND SOARS TO RECORD HIGHS, WTTC REPORTS

Business Travel Also Achieves Record Figures

India's tourism sector is experiencing an unprecedented boom, with international visitor spending reaching record highs in 2024. According to the latest data from the World Travel & Tourism Council (WTTC), international visitor expenditure in India hit ₹3.1 trillion, a significant 9% increase over the previous peak in 2019. Business

travel has also seen remarkable growth, surpassing pre-pandemic levels.

International Tourism Surges Beyond Expectations

After a period where domestic travel primarily sustained the sector, the WTTC's Economic Impact Research (EIR) reveals that international tourism in India has

not only recovered but is stronger than ever. While domestic travel remains a powerful force, with spending soaring to ₹15.5 trillion (22% above 2019 levels), the resurgence of international visitors is now propelling the industry into a new era of expansion.

The Travel & Tourism sector's overall



contribution to the Indian economy last year was nearly ₹21 trillion, a substantial 20% increase from 2019. This sector continues to be a crucial source of employment and opportunity, particularly for India's young, educated population facing rapid automation. The WTTC emphasizes that strengthening infrastructure, including high-speed rail and smart mobility solutions, will be vital to unlock the sector's full potential and elevate its GDP contribution to 10-11%.

Furthermore, the industry supported an all-time high of almost 46.5 million jobs, accounting for 9.1% of total employment across India. India welcomed 20 million international visitors in 2024, exceeding the 2019 figures by 2.3 million. This surge reaffirms India's standing as a premier global destination and highlights renewed international confidence in its diverse tourism offerings.

Policy Support Crucial for Sustained Growth

To maintain this impressive momentum, the WTTC advocates for sustained investment and targeted policy support. The organization urges the Indian government to reconsider its recent decision to reduce funding for overseas tourism promotion.

Ms. Julia Simpson, WTTC President & CEO, commented, "India's Travel & Tourism sector is experiencing unprecedented growth, with international visitor numbers now at record highs after a period of strong domestic reliance."

Simpson strongly supports the government's initiatives to simplify the e-visa process. She noted, "While visa-on-arrival and e-visa systems are in place, reciprocal policies and long delays for key markets like the U.S., where appointments are reportedly unavailable until 2026, continue to hinder tourists. Making it easier to visit India is one of the fastest ways to unlock further international arrivals and spending."

To bolster this growth and ensure long-term resilience, the WTTC has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with WTTCII to amplify India's tourism voice globally. This collaboration combines WTTC's international influence with WTTCII's strong national presence, aiming to strengthen policy coherence and provide a model for global-local tourism leadership.

The global tourism body's research also indicates that India's business travel is witnessing record expansion, with combined domestic and international

spending reaching ₹1.1 trillion last year, surpassing the 2019 peak by 2.6%.

Outlook: Continued Growth and Future Potential

The WTTC forecasts another record-breaking year for India's Travel & Tourism sector. Its economic contribution is projected to exceed ₹22 trillion in 2025, with employment in the sector expected to reach over 48 million. International visitor spend is anticipated to reach ₹3.2 trillion, while domestic traveler spending is set to hit 16 trillion.

Looking further ahead to 2035, the Travel & Tourism sector's contribution to the national economy is forecast to almost double, reaching just under ₹42 trillion, employing nearly 64 million people.

India is exceptionally well-positioned to become one of the world's most dynamic tourism economies, thanks to its vibrant blend of heritage, natural beauty, and modern innovation. This includes unlocking the significant potential of small and medium-sized enterprises, which form the backbone of the sector and drive innovation across communities and regions.

The WTTC calls on the government to match the sector's resilience and ambition with clear, consistent policy support to ensure this promising trajectory continues.



TOURISM SECTOR AIMING TO CONTRIBUTE 10% TO INDIA'S GDP BY 2030

MINISTER GAJENDRA SINGH SHEKHAWAT

The Minister underscored that aligning India's tourism share with global standards is both a strategic necessity and a reflection of the nation's burgeoning economic strength.



Union Minister for Tourism and Culture Gajendra Singh Shekhawat has set an ambitious target for the Indian tourism industry, projecting it to contribute 10% to the country's GDP by 2030 - a significant rise from the current 5% recorded in 2022-23. Speaking at the CII Annual Business Summit 2025 in New Delhi, Shekhawat emphasized that aligning India's tourism share with global standards is both a strategic imperative and a reflection of the country's growing economic strength.

Driving Growth through Domestic Tourism and Infrastructure

"India will align with global standards, with 10% of GDP coming from tourism," the minister stated, highlighting the rise of an aspirational middle class and increased participation in spiritual and experiential travel as key drivers. Shekhawat emphasized the government's substantial investments in infrastructure, including roads, railways, and airports. This development is complemented by a focused effort to enhance the visitor experience at major cultural and spiritual sites. He cited the Mahakal Corridor in Ujjain as a prime example, noting that it attracted over a million visitors in a single month, demonstrating how such projects are actively reshaping India's tourism landscape.

The minister also stressed a strategic pivot toward domestic tourism, identifying it as a major engine for sectoral growth. "India's domestic tourists have the potential to become a larger contributor to the country's tourism sector," he explained, indicating a deliberate move towards reduced dependence on international arrivals. In response to evolving post-pandemic travel preferences, the central government has urged states to develop innovative experiential tourism initiatives centered around heritage monuments. "We've asked the states to come up with new proposals," Shekhawat confirmed.

Fostering Collaboration and Future Development

Shekhawat called for robust collaboration between the government and the private sector, urging businesses to support tourism by hosting events and conferences

within India, thereby bolstering the MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions) segment. He also emphasized the critical need to improve flight capacity and streamline the overall travel experience to make tourism more accessible and appealing to a wider audience.

Referring to the government's initiative to grant tourism formal infrastructure status, he added, "The infrastructure status is going to give a major boost to private investments coming into the sector." The minister also revealed that plans are currently underway to develop an additional 50 tourism destinations across the country.

India's Soft Power and Global Ascent

During a session on "India's Soft Power: Catalyzing Global Ascendancy," Shekhawat remarked, "The perception of the entire world towards India has drastically changed as the perception of our citizens towards their own country has transformed. India is the only country in the world where people from all over come to gain knowledge and wisdom."

The session also featured insights from key industry voices. Sanjay Jaju, Secretary, Ministry of Information & Broadcasting, highlighted India's growing global influence in digital innovation and cultural content. Other prominent participants included Mr. Puneet Chhatwal, MD & CEO, Indian Hotels Company Ltd; Mr. Shashwat Goenka, Vice Chairman, RP Sanjiv Goenka Group; Mr. Rajan Navani, CEO, JetSynthesys; Rudra Chatterjee, Chairman & MD, Mr. Obeetee & Luxmi Group; and Mr. Pramod Bhasin, Chairman, ICRIER and Founder of Genpact. Jaju specifically noted that India's unique blend of tradition, creativity, and technology is firmly positioning it as a global digital powerhouse. "This soft power will transform India into a future superpower," he asserted.

As India strategically charts its path toward becoming a top tourism economy, the integration of culture, infrastructure, and innovation remains central to its overall strategy, with 2030 set as the pivotal milestone year for a transformative leap in the sector's economic contribution.



TAAI

‘RALLY FOR THE VALLEY’ BRINGS RENEWED OPTIMISM TO KASHMIR TOURISM

Jammu & Kashmir remains an unparalleled destination, renowned for its breathtaking scenery and rich cultural heritage



In a bold show of solidarity and confidence-building, the Travel Agents Association of India (TAAI), the country's oldest and most respected travel trade body, is returning to Jammu & Kashmir with its impactful initiative - Rally for the Valley. Scheduled from June 10 to 12, 2025, in Srinagar, the campaign aims to reignite tourism and reassure travelers that Kashmir remains a safe and welcoming destination.

Launched as part of TAAI's momentous 75th anniversary celebrations, the event will bring together 100 travel professionals from across India. Members will convene in Srinagar for the association's Managing Committee Meeting, while also engaging with local tourism stakeholders to underline a powerful message: "Travel to J&K is Safe."

This renewed push follows the recent unfortunate incident in Pahalgam, which cast a shadow over the region's tourism prospects. TAAI's initiative, led by over 75 members and their families, is a direct response to that narrative - aimed at replacing fear with facts on the ground.

TAAI President Mr. Sunil Kumar emphasized the symbolic importance of members physically present in Srinagar. "We are here to demonstrate that Kashmir is open and safe," he said, noting how tourism was thriving in the region until April. He called on the media and industry to help amplify this message nationwide.

Building on the success of TAAI's 2018 convention in Srinagar-which drew over 700 delegates and helped spark a tourism revival-the Rally for the Valley is once again drawing national attention to the region's potential.

Chapter Chairman Mr. Sameer Baktoo and Secretary General Mr. Sriram Patel are spearheading visits to key destinations including Pahalgam, Gulmarg, and Sonmarg. These visits aim to assess on-ground realities, gather insights, and compile a report for submission to both the Union Ministry of Tourism and state authorities, with recommendations for action.

Reaffirming TAAI's commitment, Mr. Kumar stressed that the rally is not a standalone event. "Tourism isn't just about leisure - it's about livelihoods. We will continue these efforts until Kashmir reclaims its position on the global tourism

Building on the success of TAAI's 2018 convention in Srinagar, which attracted over 700 delegates and contributed to a tourism resurgence, the "Rally for the Valley" is once again drawing national attention to the region's potential.

map," he said. He also urged the government to ensure visible safety measures and sustained promotion efforts.

A Message of Unity and Resilience

This campaign is also a symbolic gesture of unity across the travel fraternity and a tribute to the resilience of the people of Jammu & Kashmir. It acknowledges the role of the armed forces and seeks to bridge the gap between perception and reality regarding travel safety in the region.

Mr. Raja Yaqoob, IAS, Director of Tourism, Jammu & Kashmir, welcomed the initiative,



Deal with someone you can trust
"A TAAI MEMBER"

stating: "TAAI's consistent support is invaluable. Their visit will go a long way in reassuring both the travel industry and potential tourists. We are confident this will strengthen our efforts toward sustainable and responsible tourism."

Mr. Sameer Baktoo added: "With over 110 active TAAI-affiliated agencies in J&K, this initiative represents our collective commitment to rebuilding confidence and boosting the region's image. It's more than symbolic-it's a sincere step toward revival."

Seamless Support for Delegates

To ensure smooth participation, TAAI has arranged special airfares and discounted hotel packages for members. With registrations limited to 100 delegates, the Rally for the Valley promises to be a milestone event in TAAI's journey of promoting national integration and tourism development.



J&K CM OMAR ABDULLAH CHAMPIONS TOURISM REVIVAL, COMMENDS TAAI'S CRUCIAL SUPPORT

Jammu & Kashmir remains an unparalleled destination, renowned for its breathtaking scenery and rich cultural heritage

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah addressed the Travel Agents Association of India's (TAAI) "Rally for the Valley - Let's Go to Jammu and Kashmir" event on Wednesday, June 11,

2025, a significant initiative for tourism revival in the region. During his speech, the Chief Minister reiterated his government's steadfast commitment to enhancing the visitor experience in Jammu and Kashmir,

emphasizing that tourists should leave with a desire to return.

"Tourists have a journey or an experience. They go home and tell others about it. I think there are lessons we've all learned



over the past few months," the Chief Minister remarked, acknowledging recent challenges to the tourism sector.

Improving Infrastructure and Building Confidence

The Chief Minister revealed that the J&K government is utilizing this time to improve infrastructure and the overall visitor experience. "I have already given instructions to the cable car corporation to upgrade the gondola in Gulmarg, so that capacity is increased, ticketing is improved, and the overall experience is enhanced. The same applies elsewhere in J&K," he stated.

Chief Minister Abdullah extended his gratitude to the TAAI delegation and its President, Sunil Kumar, for their visit to Kashmir. "At this moment, I would like to extend my thanks to the President of the TAAI delegation, Sunil Kumar, and all of you who have come from outside J&K for your trust and confidence in us," he said. He added, "It is often said: you truly know who your friends are in difficult times. Everyone wants to be your friend in good times."

Acknowledging Solidarity and Resilience

The Chief Minister, who also holds the tourism portfolio, acknowledged the deep commitment shown by the TAAI delegation, especially in the wake of recent events. "Let me express deep gratitude, not just from my side or from the government's side, but on behalf of everyone connected with tourism in Kashmir—thank you for being here and for giving us this boost," he said. He spoke frankly about the tragic incident on April 22 in Baisaran, which claimed the lives of 25 tourists and one local, acknowledging its profound impact. "It's hard to talk about the future without looking back to understand how we got here. The tragic incident on April 22 in Baisaran must never be forgotten—and it shouldn't be," he stressed. "That tragedy touched everyone in J&K. For the first time in my memory, people across Jammu and especially in Kashmir spontaneously came out to denounce the attack, to speak out and stand in solidarity."

Chief Minister Abdullah highlighted the genuine and heartfelt response from the Kashmiri people. "What happened after April 22 was not orchestrated by any political party or organization – it was spontaneous, heartfelt. The people of Kashmir wanted to show the rest of the country and the world that the attack was not in their name. It didn't represent them,



wasn't in line with their values, and they didn't want to remain silent and let anyone believe that they were complicit."

Looking Ahead to a Brighter Season

Despite current challenges, the Chief Minister expressed optimism for the future. "There is no doubt that we are in a winter of catastrophic proportions. But winter is just a season. It can't last forever. The snow must melt."

He also highlighted the significant improvements in connectivity, particularly the new rail services to the region. "Today Kashmir has a railway. You were able to cross the highest railway bridge in the world – which is a testament to the hard work of engineers and the companies that built it. You crossed the only cable-stayed railway bridge in the country. And you did this in a region of extreme challenges," he proudly stated.

Abdullah encouraged more people to

experience these engineering marvels. "We hope more people will come. The reason I mention the highest railway bridge in the world is because there may be a time limit on how long we can claim this record. We should have as many people as possible cross this bridge. Because right now, we can claim we have the highest railway bridge in the world."

The Chief Minister concluded by expressing his eagerness to continue the productive relationship with TAAI. "I look forward to working with all of you so that we can begin to revive tourism in Jammu and Kashmir. The relationship with Kashmir is a very special one, and I hope it continues."

The event saw the presence of key officials and stakeholders, including Advisor to the CM Nasir Aslam Wani, Members of Legislative Assembly Mubarak Gul, Farooq Ahmed Shah, and Tanvir Sadiq, renowned hoteliers Mushtaq Chaya and Mushtaq Burza, President TAAI Sunil Kumar, and the Chairman of TAAI's J&K chapter.



IATO DELEGATION MEETS J&K CHIEF MINISTER, ASSURED OF FULL SUPPORT FOR TOURISM REVIVAL

“Rubaroo Jammu & Kashmir” Campaign Concludes with Positive Assessment

A 30-member delegation from the Indian Association of Tour Operators (IATO), led by its President, Ravi Gosain, held a productive meeting with the Honorable Chief Minister of Jammu

& Kashmir, Omar Abdullah, in Srinagar on June 17, 2025. The Chief Minister extended his gratitude to the delegation for their initiative and provided strong assurances regarding the safety and

security of tourists within the region. He urged the delegates to disseminate the message that Kashmir is a safe travel destination among their professional networks.



“Rubaroo Jammu & Kashmir” Campaign Concludes with Positive Assessment

The meeting was part of IATO’s “Rubaroo Jammu & Kashmir” campaign, a three-day initiative (June 14-17) during which members explored various areas of Pahalgam and Srinagar. The delegation reported finding the valley peaceful and its residents welcoming.

“It was crucial to assess the ground situation, and during our three-day stay, we found the state to be as safe as any other location,” stated Ravi Gosain. “Furthermore, we have received assurances from the highest levels of government, which instills great confidence in all of us. I am confident that tourist flow to the state will return to normal in the coming period.”

Restoring Confidence After Recent Cancellations

Gosain acknowledged that IATO members had experienced numerous cancellations from both domestic and international tourists following an incident in Pahalgam. “Clearly, sentiment was impacted, but it is vital to restore confidence and revive



tourism,” he added. “This visit is a step in that direction, and we are completely satisfied with the safety arrangements implemented by the government.”

Invitation to IATO’s 40th Annual Convention

The IATO delegation also took the opportunity to invite the Chief Minister to the 40th IATO Annual Convention, scheduled to take place in Puri, Odisha, in August 2025. This convention is expected to gather 1000-1200 delegates from

across India, offering the Chief Minister a significant platform for engagement. Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, in principle, accepted IATO’s invitation and assured them that the Jammu & Kashmir Tourism Department would participate with a robust delegation. The IATO Convention is set to be held in Puri, Odisha, from August 22nd to 25th, 2025.

IATO, established in 1982, serves as the national apex body for India’s tourism industry.



KERALA TO HOST FIRST WEDDING & MICE CONCLAVE IN KOCHI, AUG 2025

The event will be held from August 14 to 16, 2025

In a significant move to establish Kerala as a premier destination for weddings and business events, the Adv. P.A. Mohamed Riyas, Minister for Tourism, Government of Kerala, has officially announced the "Wedding & MICE Conclave - Powered by Kerala Travel Mart." The event will be held from August 14 to 16, 2025, with the grand inaugural session at the Grand Hyatt



Kochi Bolgatty on August 14, followed by the main conclave at the Le Méridien Convention Centre, Kochi.

This first-of-its-kind event is organized by the Kerala Travel Mart (KTM) Society in collaboration with the Government of Kerala. It aims to capitalize on the booming destination wedding and MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and





Adv. P.A. Mohamed Riyas,
Minister for Tourism,
Government of Kerala,

Exhibitions) segments. The conclave will bring together top stakeholders from India and abroad, including wedding planners, event organizers, corporate buyers, luxury hospitality brands, Destination Management Companies (DMCs), and tourism boards.

According to Mr. Jose Pradeep, President

of the Kerala Travel Mart Society, while Kerala is already celebrated globally as a serene leisure destination, this new initiative represents a strategic shift to expand the state's tourism offerings into high-value segments. The post-pandemic resurgence in travel has seen a remarkable rise in demand for experiential and value-driven event destinations-areas where Kerala holds immense untapped potential.

Tourism India, a leading travel and tourism publication in South Asia, will serve as the Allied Media Partner for this visionary initiative and collaborate throughout the campaign. In conjunction with the conclave, Tourism India will publish a premium international handbook titled: "Kerala Tourism - MICE & Destination Wedding Planner." This exclusive publication is designed to promote Kerala as a luxury wedding and corporate events destination. It will act as a comprehensive marketing and planning tool for national and international MICE organizers, destination wedding planners, event management companies, corporates, and high-end leisure travel consultants. The handbook will highlight Kerala's scenic venues, luxury resorts, heritage properties, convention centers, connectivity, cultural offerings,



Mr. Jose Pradeep,
President,
Kerala Travel Mart Society,

and event-ready infrastructure, providing global planners with practical tools and destination inspiration.

The Wedding & MICE Conclave - Powered by KTM is poised to be a strategic platform for networking, business development, and the global positioning of Brand Kerala in the experiential tourism space.



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UTTARAKHAND LAUNCHES STRATEGY TO REVIVE CHAR DHAM YATRA AMIDST INITIAL PILGRIM DROP

Char Dham Yatra 2025 Sees Low Turnout in Early Phase

Uttarakhand
Simply Heaven!

Divine Uttarakhand
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Government of Uttarakhand is committed to ensure that your Chardham Yatra is smooth, secure and fulfilling.

Embark on your spiritual journey and experience divine energy at Yamunotri, Gangotri, Kedarnath, Badrinath & Hemkund Sahib.

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Booking of Helicopter tickets to Kedarnath is available only on www.hellyatra.jrcto.co.in

The Uttarakhand government and its implementing agency, the Uttarakhand Tourism Development Board, are actively working on a new strategy to boost pilgrim footfall for the ongoing Char Dham Yatra. The pilgrimage, which commenced in late April, has experienced a concerning drop in numbers during its initial phase, a trend that officials and stakeholders are working to reverse.

The four revered shrines - Yamunotri, Gangotri, Kedarnath, and Badrinath - opened their doors to devotees starting on April 30th (Akshaya Tritiya). However, data from the Dehradun-based Social Development for Communities (SDC) Foundation reveals a steep 21% decline in pilgrim numbers in the first three weeks of the yatra this year compared to the corresponding period in 2024. Between April 30 and May 20, 2025, a total of 10,91,406 pilgrims visited the shrines, significantly lower than the 13,84,688 recorded last year. The downward trend was particularly sharp in the first week, with a 26% decrease by May 7 compared to 2024 figures.

Reasons Behind the Lull

Officials and experts attribute the downturn to a combination of factors. A primary reason cited is the recently concluded Mahakumbh in Prayagraj, a rare event that attracted over 60 crore devotees.

Brijesh Sati, General Secretary of the Char Dham Teerth Purohit Mahapanchayat, suggested that many middle-class pilgrims who attended the Mahakumbh may not have the resources for another major pilgrimage in the same year.

Additionally, heightened geopolitical tensions following a terror attack in Pahalgam, Jammu and Kashmir, and a series of missile strikes along the Indo-Pak border in early May, are believed to have deterred pilgrims. Unpredictable weather conditions in the Himalayas, including biting cold temperatures and repeated IMD weather warnings for heavy rainfall and hailstorms, have also posed a significant challenge for devotees.

Government's Proactive Response

Despite the challenges, the Uttarakhand government has taken proactive steps to ensure a safe and organized yatra. Officials note that some of the initial decline can be attributed to improved crowd management measures, including:

- **Staggered Registration:** The government launched online registration as early as March 20, 2025, and implemented a 75% online registration cap to manage crowd flow.

- **Enhanced Security:** Mandatory Aadhaar verification and stringent document checks were introduced to enhance security.

- **Expanded Access:** To accommodate pilgrims without internet access, offline registration counters were opened along the yatra routes from April 25 at key locations like Haridwar and Rishikesh.

- **Infrastructure and Safety:** Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami has underscored the commitment to making the yatra "Sugam, Sukhad aur Surakshit" (Easy, Comfortable, and Safe). The administration has implemented robust health screening programs, deployed emergency response teams, and installed CCTV cameras along the routes. Following geopolitical developments, the Chief Minister also directed officials to step up security for the yatra and other key state establishments.

Balancing Devotion and Sustainability

As Uttarakhand positions itself as a year-round spiritual destination, there is growing emphasis on sustainable pilgrimage

The revered Char Dham Yatra 2025, one of India's holiest pilgrimages encompassing Yamunotri, Gangotri, Kedarnath, and Badrinath in the Himalayan state of Uttarakhand, has seen a significant decline in pilgrim footfall during its initial weeks. Despite the spiritual pull of the sacred journey, the Yatra has recorded over 21% fewer pilgrims compared to the same period in 2024, with officials citing multiple contributing factors.

tourism. The state government is urging pilgrims to travel responsibly, avoid peak congestion, and prioritize environmental consciousness, especially as the Char Dham Yatra traverses ecologically sensitive zones above 3,000 metres in altitude.

As the pilgrimage season continues, the state is also emphasizing sustainable tourism. A senior police official involved in yatra preparations noted that the reduced crowds have surprisingly eased logistical challenges, making traffic and crowd management significantly easier with no major congestion issues reported so far.

While this has eased operational burdens, the long-term economic impact on local communities remains a concern. The yatra is a crucial source of annual income for hoteliers, porters, and small businesses in the region.

As Chief Minister Dhami rightly noted in a recent security meeting following the India-Pakistan developments, "Char Dham Yatra is not just a religious event,

but an economic and cultural lifeline for Uttarakhand. We are committed to making it safer, smoother, and spiritually enriching for every devotee."

Awaiting a Surge

Despite the initial slump, stakeholders remain optimistic. Tourism and Culture Minister Satpal Maharaj stated that pilgrim numbers have already started rising, with over 31 lakh registrations recorded as of late May, including 8.7 lakh for Kedarnath alone. With the summer holidays now in full swing, authorities anticipate a significant surge in footfall.

The Char Dham Yatra is scheduled to continue until its closing dates in October and November, with Yamunotri and Kedarnath closing around October 23, Gangotri on October 22, and Badrinath on November 6. Stakeholders are hopeful that favorable weather and a stable geopolitical situation will encourage more pilgrims to undertake the sacred journey in the coming weeks.



UTTAR PRADESH UNVEILS INDIA'S FIRST JUNGLE SAFARI VISTADOME TRAIN, BOOSTING ECO-TOURISM

An unparalleled journey connecting the Katarniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary with the Dudhwa Tiger Reserve, traversing the rich biodiversity of the Terai region



Chuggle into the Wild.
The Jungle is Calling.

In a significant stride for eco-tourism, the Government of Uttar Pradesh, in collaboration with Indian Railways, has launched India's inaugural Jungle Safari Vistadome Train. This innovative rail service now offers nature enthusiasts and adventure seekers an unparalleled journey connecting the Katarniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary with the Dudhwa Tiger Reserve, traversing the rich biodiversity of the Terai region.

The core of this new experience lies in its specially designed Vistadome coaches. These coaches provide panoramic views of the surrounding forests, wetlands, and diverse wildlife, thanks to their expansive glass windows, transparent rooftops, and 360-degree rotating seats. Passengers can now observe flora and fauna in their natural habitat from the comfort of their seats, making it an ideal option for families, photographers, and eco-tourism advocates.

Currently, the train operates exclusively on weekends, positioning it as a perfect short getaway.

Route, Schedule, and Affordable Fares

Designated as Train No. 52259/52260, the Vistadome safari train runs on the Bichia–Mailani Tourist Passenger route, covering a 107-kilometer stretch in approximately 4 hours and 25 minutes.

Operating Schedule:

Outbound: Departs Bichia at 11:45 AM, arriving in Mailani at 4:10 PM.

Return: Leaves Mailani at 6:05 AM, reaching Bichia by 10:30 AM.

The train includes halts at nine stations, strategically located to serve key eco-tourism spots such as Dudhwa, Palia Kalan, and Bhira Kheri. An incredibly accessible fare of ₹275 per person is set for the journey between Katarniaghat and Dudhwa.

“One Destination, Three Forests” Initiative

This Vistadome safari train is a crucial element of the state's broader “One Destination, Three Forests” initiative, spearheaded by the Uttar Pradesh Eco Tourism Board. This ambitious project aims to unify Dudhwa National Park, Katarniaghat Wildlife Sanctuary, and Kishanpur Wildlife Sanctuary into a cohesive wildlife circuit, promising a comprehensive and diverse eco-tourism experience.

To further enhance accessibility for both

Beyond its tourism appeal, the Jungle Safari Vistadome train is expected to generate significant positive impacts on the local economy

domestic and international visitors, the Eco Tourism Board is actively developing special travel packages from Lucknow to Katarniaghat, with potential subsidies to make eco-travel even more affordable.

Fostering Sustainable Local Development

Beyond its tourism appeal, the Jungle Safari Vistadome train is expected to

generate significant positive impacts on the local economy. The initiative actively encourages the involvement of local homestays, eco-resorts, and travel operators, thereby fostering employment opportunities and promoting sustainable livelihoods within the forest-adjacent communities of the state.

An Unforgettable Journey Through Nature

For wildlife enthusiasts, birdwatchers, landscape photographers, and nature lovers alike, this Vistadome jungle safari train offers an unparalleled opportunity to traverse one of India's most ecologically rich zones. With a focus on comfort, affordability, and sustainability, the journey into Uttar Pradesh's natural wonders is now just a ticket away.

Plan your adventure and book your seats to discover the natural treasures of Uttar Pradesh like never before!



UTTAR PRADESH ECO-TOURISM DRIVE EMPOWERS THARU TRIBES IN DUDHWA REGION

UP Tourism's broader strategy for boosting eco-tourism places emphasis on integrating local tribes and residents into the growth narrative





In a move to bolster both sustainable tourism and local community empowerment, the Uttar Pradesh Eco-Tourism Development Board recently organized an insightful interaction focused on the Dudhwa National Park region. The gathering brought together homestay owners, members of the Tharu tribal community, resort operators, hotel associations, forest officials, and nature guides, all collaborating to strengthen eco-tourism practices and enhance community engagement.

Uttar Pradesh's broader strategy for boosting eco-tourism places significant emphasis on integrating local tribes and residents into the growth narrative. A prime example is the inclusion of the Tharu tribals in the Dudhwa region, a key initiative highlighted during a recent meeting chaired by Mr. Thakur Jaiveer Singh, Minister for Tourism and Culture, Government of Uttar Pradesh. This approach aims to ensure that the economic benefits of eco-tourism directly reach local communities, fostering

sustainable development and cultural preservation. Minister Singh emphasized the unique contribution of the Tharu community: "Living in harmony with nature in villages along the Dudhwa Tiger Reserve, culturally rich Tharu tribals are known for their deeply rooted forest-based traditions, sustainable agriculture, and a close-knit community with unique traditions that include dress, jewelry, folk songs, and dance. Itineraries being developed for Dudhwa have included interactions with these tribals so that the community benefits from the visitors."

Officials confirmed that the government has taken significant steps to involve local communities in tourism development. "While on one hand, the idea is to aid their economy, their role is also crucial to the conservation of the forest resource," stated Prakhar Mishra, Director of Eco-Tourism, Uttar Pradesh.

Mishra noted that many Tharu families have traditionally relied solely on small agricultural plots for their livelihood. In response, the department is actively

supporting them in developing homestays and implementing schemes like "bed and breakfast" services.

A preliminary study indicated high demand for experiential tourism across India. "Taking a cue from that, UP's eco-tourism developed a model that benefits all-the locals, the state, and even the visitors," Mishra explained. "Specifically for the Tharus and Dudhwa, visitors can have the chance to feast on their traditional delicacies such as Dhikri made from rice, Patauta, and Ek Patiya Saag. The bonus is scores of big and small stories of living with nature and encountering big cats and other animals."

To further enhance livelihoods and preserve traditional skills, initiatives like the Tharu Shilp Gram have been launched by the UP Eco-Tourism Board. Located near the tiger reserve, this craft village showcases handmade jute products created by Tharu artisans, including bags, mats, caps, decor, and accessories—all produced using techniques passed down through generations.

GOA UNVEILS LANDMARK TOWN SQUARE PROJECT IN PORVORIM

₹120.97 Crore PROJECT Set to Transform Tourism Landscape

The Goa Budget 2025-26, presented by Chief Minister Dr. Pramod Sawant, places tourism at the heart of the state's development strategy with a record allocation of 440.98 crore dedicated to the sector. The paperless budget-Sawant's seventh-announces a slew of strategic initiatives aimed at transforming Goa into a sustainable, high-value international tourism destination, while also ensuring inclusivity for domestic and budget travelers.

In a significant policy push, the government has proposed tax holidays, including a 50% rebate on state GST, stamp duty exemptions, and fee waivers for investors developing three-star and above hotels or hospitals in hinterland talukas like Bicholim, Canacona, Quepem, and Ponda. This initiative aligns with Tourism Minister Rohan Khaunte's 'Goa Beyond Beaches' campaign, which promotes rural and cultural tourism across the state.

To reinforce Goa's position on the global tourism map, the budget outlines 11 ambitious projects including a new cruise terminal, jetty terminal, aero-tourism with skydiving and drone activities, an Oceanarium, mini convention center in Panaji, caravan parks in Kerim, and wayside amenities. A digital nomad village and a digital museum honoring Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj are also on the cards, reflecting the government's drive to diversify tourism offerings.

The proposed Tourism Ambassador



Program aims to train and skill local youth, addressing the sector's manpower challenges and enhancing service quality. Additionally, a 10 crore allocation under a central scheme will support tourism projects in hinterland villages, promoting eco-tourism and heritage experiences.

Recognizing the challenges tourists face with local transport, the CM announced the integration of taxi services into a digital app aggregator platform-an attempt to rectify a long-standing pain point that sparked a social media backlash last year. A new "plug & play" model is also proposed to encourage start-ups and coworking hubs in tourism-related ventures.

The budget also includes support infrastructure: a single-window mechanism will facilitate speedy approvals for electricity, water, and sewage connections for tourism-related projects. Goa is also betting on cruise and marine tourism as major growth sectors, with immersive marine exhibits and port infrastructure enhancements planned.

Urban development and tourism intertwine in the Smart City initiatives. Projects worth 423 crore will be executed,

with Panaji receiving 135 crore under the Centre's Cities 2.0 Mission. Smart roads and smart illumination are part of this urban makeover that complements tourism growth.

Further enhancing Goa's hospitality ecosystem, a new city near Mopa Airport has been proposed under a central scheme, signaling the state's intent to leverage connectivity and create new tourism hubs around the Greenfield airport.

Tourism accounts for over 16.4% of Goa's gross domestic product and provides more than 35% of employment in the state. A former TTAG (Travel and Tourism Association of Goa) President welcomed the 440 crore allocation, stating that the government's intention is clear-if implemented effectively, these measures could deliver a new growth trajectory for the state's tourism economy.

"Sustainable tourism, responsible development, and digital readiness are the three pillars of this year's tourism plan," said CM Sawant, asserting that Goa is ready to welcome quality tourists while protecting its culture, ecology, and the interests of its residents.

With a Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) projected at 1.38 lakh crore and per capita income at 9.69 lakh, Goa is aiming high-not just economically, but experientially. The 2025-26 budget underscores tourism not merely as a sector, but as a catalyst for inclusive and future-ready growth.

TAMARA LEISURE EXPERIENCES APPOINTS SAMIR M.C. AS CEO; SHRUTI SHIBULAL TRANSITIONS TO EXECUTIVE VICE CHAIR



Tamara Leisure Experiences Pvt. Ltd., has announced a key leadership transition with the appointment of Mr. Samir M.C. as Chief Executive Officer, effective June 16, 2025. He takes over the reins from Ms. Shruti Shibulal, who will now serve as the Executive Vice Chair of the Board.

Bringing with him over three decades of distinguished leadership at ITC Hotels and IHG Hotels & Resorts, Mr. Samir is poised to steer Tamara into its next phase of growth and transformation. Known for his operational expertise, strategic foresight, and deep understanding of the evolving hospitality landscape, Samir's appointment marks a new chapter for the company as it continues to expand its footprint across India and beyond.

"I am thrilled to share that I've been appointed Chief Executive Officer at

Tamara Leisure Experiences, a purpose-led hospitality company that is redefining responsible travel through sustainability, innovation, and human-centric design," said Mr. Samir. "Tamara's bold vision and values resonate deeply with me - and I am energised by the opportunity to shape the next phase of growth for this distinctive hospitality company."

Ms. Shruti Shibulal, who has led Tamara as CEO for nearly seven years, will now focus on governance, culture-building, and long-term strategy in her new role. Her leadership has been instrumental in establishing Tamara as a pioneer in responsible tourism, with properties known for sustainable design, community engagement, and operational excellence.

"After nearly seven incredible years as CEO of Tamara Leisure Experiences, I'm stepping into the role of Executive

Vice Chair - a transition that allows me to remain deeply engaged in shaping our vision, values, and growth," said Ms. Shruti. "It's with great pride that I welcome Samir M.C. as our new CEO. With global experience, strategic clarity, and a shared belief in responsible hospitality, Samir brings the leadership and insight to guide Tamara into its next chapter."

The leadership shift represents both evolution and continuity, as the company stays rooted in its founding principles while embracing new avenues of growth and innovation. As Tamara Leisure Experiences charts its future, the synergy between Ms. Shruti Shibulal and Mr. Samir M.C. promises to strengthen its position as a forward-thinking hospitality brand defined by purpose, excellence, and impact.

EMBRACING THE EARTH: GOA'S UNIQUE 'CHIKHAL KALO' FESTIVAL RETURNS JULY 7TH

Celebrated exclusively in this Ponda taluka village on the twelfth day of Ashadh (the fourth Hindu month), Chikhal Kalo is dedicated to Balkrishna, the endearing child form of Lord Krishna



As Goa's skies open with the monsoon rains and the earth awakens, the village of Marcel responds with a cherished tradition: Chikhal Kalo. This deeply rooted festival, held annually at the sacred Sri Devki-Krishna Temple in Marcel, is more than just an event; it's a vibrant, communal expression of gratitude to the Earth, a devotion to heritage, and a powerful symbol of unity. Set for July 7, 2025, this year's Chikhal Kalo promises to once again transform the quiet village into a lively spectacle of celebration.

A Playful Homage to Childhood Krishna

Celebrated exclusively in this Ponda taluka village on the twelfth day of Ashadh (the fourth Hindu month), Chikhal Kalo is dedicated to Balkrishna, the endearing child form of Lord Krishna, renowned for his playful innocence. The festival's name, literally translating to "mud play," hints at its core, yet it encompasses far more than simple games. The day begins in the early hours with villagers gathering at the temple, offering blessings through devotional rituals and the rhythmic sounds of traditional Goan instruments. Following these invocations, the temple grounds become a sacred arena where participants joyfully immerse themselves in the fertile soil for spirited, traditional games.

These activities, from chendu fali (mud ball games) to khushti (wrestling bouts), re-enact tales from Lord Krishna's childhood, reflecting his love for mischievous fun and his profound connection to the earth and its people. Beyond their religious symbolism, these games powerfully reaffirm the vital role of soil as a life-giver, deeply resonating with Goa's agrarian heritage.

Unity in Play: The Dahi Handi and Communal Feasting

A highlight of Chikhal Kalo is the captivating Dahi Handi ceremony. In this time-honored tradition, teams form human pyramids to reach and break clay pots suspended high above the mud field, typically filled with curd, butter, or sweets. This event not only captures the jubilant spirit of Lord Krishna, famously fond of butter, but also beautifully embodies themes of collaboration, perseverance, and collective unity.

As villagers and visitors dive into the mud, devotional songs and rhythmic chants



blend with the beating drums. A unique sight unfolds beneath the ancient peepal tree in the temple courtyard: devotees on a platform hurl puran polis, bananas, and laddoos into the muddy arena. The thrill of catching these sweets mid-air adds an extra layer of spontaneity and laughter to the day's rituals.

The Heartbeat of the Festival: Music and Community

Music is the soul of Chikhal Kalo. From dawn until the rituals conclude, the air reverberates with the sounds of traditional percussion instruments like ghumat, shamel, and taal, echoing through the village as a spiritual call. The powerful chant of "Jai Hari Vitthal" surges through the crowd, invoking divine presence and anchoring the entire celebration in collective devotion. These melodies, passed down through generations, bind the community in rhythm, faith, and shared joy.

As cheers rise, drums beat, and pots shatter, a wave of communal joy washes over the grounds. It's a moment of collective exaltation that unites all participants—villagers, tourists, children, and elders—in a shared spiritual and cultural experience.

Experience Goa's Living Heritage

Visitors from across Goa, other Indian states, and even international tourists are warmly encouraged to participate or simply observe this unique festival. Whether you choose to jump into the mud or witness the celebration from the sidelines, the experience is deeply moving and unforgettable.

For cultural travelers, photographers, families, and students of history and anthropology, Chikhal Kalo offers a rare opportunity to witness a living tradition that

beautifully intertwines ecology, mythology, and social unity. In a world increasingly disconnected from nature, Chikhal Kalo serves as a potent reminder of our bond with the Earth. It is a celebration of fertility, gratitude, and sustainable living, as much as it is about joyful play and deep piety. It underscores that the soil beneath our feet is not merely a resource, but a sacred link to life itself.

Join the Celebration: Goa Tourism's Special Program

To further preserve and promote Goa's intangible cultural heritage, the Department of Tourism, Government of Goa, is organizing a special two-day program for Chikhal Kalo 2025 on July 5th and 6th, leading up to the main event, also at the Sri Devki-Krishna Temple in Marcel. Visitors are heartily invited to join this vibrant celebration and experience Goa's living traditions through devotional music, traditional games, and spirited community participation.

This unique blend of environmental mindfulness, spiritual depth, and unadulterated joy makes Chikhal Kalo one of the most meaningful and unforgettable festivals in the state. The Goa Tourism extends a warm invitation to all to witness and participate in Chikhal Kalo 2025. Come and discover a side of Goa that extends beyond its famous beaches—dive into its villages, its values, and its vibrant cultural soul.

Whether you're a curious traveler, a culture enthusiast, or a spiritual seeker, Chikhal Kalo offers something rare: a celebration where the Earth itself is the stage, the people are the performers, and unity is the message.

MEGHALAYA'S MISTY HILLS BECKON

ARAB INFLUENCERS EYE NORTHEASTERN STATE AS PRIME SUMMER ESCAPE

Gateway Malabar Holidays, specializing in curated holidays and medical value travel packages for high-end Arab travelers to India, spearheaded the initiative to invite Arab influencers to Meghalaya



In a significant move to diversify its tourism portfolio, the picturesque northeastern state of Meghalaya recently hosted its first-ever delegation of prominent Arab social media influencers. Their glowing endorsement of the region as an ideal summer retreat for Gulf travelers is set to put Meghalaya firmly on the Middle Eastern tourism map.

The visit, orchestrated by Gateway Malabar Holidays, saw influencers Mr. Rajis Al Khudari from Saudi Arabia, and Mr. Ali Habeeb and Mr. Abdullah (Abu Dana) from the UAE, explore Meghalaya's famed waterfalls, refreshing climate, and serene landscapes. Known for their large followings and passion for nature, monsoons, and discovering hidden gems, the influencers were reportedly captivated by the state's natural beauty and warm hospitality. Their experiences are expected to generate significant interest among their thousands of followers back home, particularly those seeking an escape from the intense summer heat of the Gulf region.

Gateway Malabar Holidays, a leading Indian Destination Management Company (DMC) specializing in curated holidays and medical value travel packages for high-end Arab travelers to India, spearheaded the initiative to invite Arab influencers to



This focused initiative is being viewed as more than just a tourism campaign. Organizers believe it represents a significant step towards building cultural bridges and unlocking economic opportunities for Meghalaya and, by extension, Northeast India. The endorsement from respected Arab voices, coupled with the proactive approach of the Meghalaya Tourism Department, signals a promising new chapter for the region's presence in the international tourism arena.

"This is just the beginning," added Husain, emphasizing the long-term vision for positioning Meghalaya as a unique and welcoming destination for travelers from the Arab world.

Meghalaya. Led by its Managing Director, Mr. Jihad Hussain, the company aimed to showcase the beauty and vibrancy of India's northeastern states. This pioneering effort received strong backing from the Meghalaya Tourism Department. Mr. Cyril Darlong Diengdoh, IAS, Director of Tourism, Meghalaya, warmly welcomed the delegation and expressed his full support for the project. Recognizing the untapped potential of the Arab market, Director Diengdoh also facilitated a crucial meeting between the influencers, Gateway Malabar Holidays, and the Meghalaya Travel Agents' Association, laying the foundation for sustained collaboration.

Mr. Jihad Husain, Founder & Managing Director of Gateway Malabar Holidays & Medisafar, whose companies have a two-decade history of promoting Indian tourism in the Gulf, highlighted the strategic timing of the visit. "With the summer vacation season approaching in the Middle East, Gateway Malabar Holidays is rolling out a strategic plan to promote Meghalaya as a premier destination for Arab travelers," he stated.

The plan to attract Arab tourists is comprehensive. Key strategies include developing customized travel experiences tailored to cultural preferences, exploring the feasibility of direct flight routes from Gulf countries to Northeastern airports like Guwahati or Shillong, and creating Arabic-language tourism guides and promotional materials. Further collaborations with Arab influencers, training programs for local hospitality staff on Arab cultural expectations, and participation in major tourism expos across Gulf countries are also in the pipeline.



CIAL 2.0 COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT EMBRACES COMPREHENSIVE DIGITAL TRANSFORMATION

During the launch, Chief Minister of Kerala Mr. Pinarayi Vijayan underscored the paramount importance of ensuring the utmost safety for air travelers and safeguarding airport assets



Cochin International Airport Ltd. (CIAL) marked a significant leap into the future with the grand launch of CIAL 2.0, a transformative initiative poised to fully digitize airport operations and elevate the passenger experience through cutting-edge artificial intelligence, advanced automation, and robust cybersecurity measures. Kerala's Chief Minister and Chairman of CIAL, Mr Pinarayi Vijayan, inaugurated the 200-crore project at the CIAL Trade Fair & Exhibition Centre.

Chief Minister Vijayan underscored the paramount importance of ensuring the utmost safety for air travelers and safeguarding airport assets. He highlighted that the CIAL 2.0 project meticulously integrates various initiatives centered on artificial intelligence, automation, and impregnable cybersecurity, all designed to address emerging challenges in the digital landscape and significantly enhance the overall travel experience. He noted that CIAL is on its way to becoming an entirely digital airport.

Mr.S. Suhas IAS, Managing Director of CIAL, articulated the vision behind CIAL 2.0, stating, "Cochin International Airport is embracing the future with CIAL 2.0 – a visionary leap into digital transformation that places intelligence at the heart of every operation. These projects, envisioned under the guidance of our esteemed Chairman and Board of Directors, represent a holistic upgrade of CIAL's digital backbone. This includes fortifying digital infrastructure, enhancing security and operational efficiency, introducing next-generation security systems, and improving passenger convenience through AI-driven solutions."

At the core of this transformation is the newly established Cyber Defence Operations Centre (CDOC), a state-of-the-art facility dedicated to proactively protecting digital infrastructure. This pioneering, full-fledged on-premises server facility, supported by CDAC, is the first of its kind at an Indian airport. It boasts real-time threat intelligence, continuous 24x7 monitoring, and rapid incident response capabilities. Given the rising cyber threats in the aviation sector, the CDOC employs advanced security tools to detect, neutralize, and preempt external threats such as hacking attempts,

malware intrusions, and ransomware attacks. This real-time digital shield guarantees that CIAL's extensive network and IT infrastructure remain resilient, uninterrupted, and highly secure, setting a national benchmark in airport cybersecurity.

Passenger security and convenience are also being revolutionized. The introduction of full-body scanners promises fast, contactless, and non-intrusive passenger screening, aligning with international standards. These enhancements ensure seamless yet thorough security checks without compromising traveler comfort. Furthermore, the deployment of an Automated Tray Retrieval System (ATRS) at security checkpoints will significantly improve processing speed and passenger convenience. This system automates the movement of security trays, reducing manual handling and substantially accelerating cabin baggage screening.

Airport and perimeter security are being fortified with a powerful, AI-driven surveillance network. Over 4,000 intelligent cameras are now actively monitoring terminal interiors, airside zones, and other sensitive areas. These AI-powered systems utilize deep learning for sophisticated behavior analysis, real-time threat detection, and swift response, leading to a quantum leap in security precision and situational awareness, ensuring a safe

environment for all. The Next-Gen Security Infrastructure is further bolstered with advanced tools, including a Bomb Detection and Disposal System (BDDS) featuring new liquid explosive detectors, portable X-ray devices, and Threat Containment Vessels (TCV) for safe handling of high-risk materials.

The airport's digital backbone has undergone comprehensive Core System Modernisation. This includes a revamped Airport Operational Database (AODB), Flight Information Display System (FIDS), and Automatic Flight Announcement System. CIAL has also introduced Common Use Passenger Processing Systems (CUPPS), allowing flexible, shared-use counters for airlines. A next-generation Data Centre, based on Hyper-Converged Infrastructure (HCI), now offers scalable and secure backend support, complemented by an upgraded network infrastructure ensuring high-speed and fail-safe connectivity across all airport operations.

CIAL 2.0 also introduces an Innovation Suite of smart digital services aimed at redefining convenience and automation for the modern traveler. These include facial recognition check-in, AI-based baggage tracking, a 'FindMe' lost item tracker, prepaid cab booking kiosks, and seamless integration with Bar-Coded Boarding Pass (BCBP) and DigiYatra.



BIAL KEMPEGOWDA AIRPORT TERMINAL 2 ACHIEVES 5-STAR SKYTRAX RATING, FIRST IN INDIA

This coveted Skytrax 5-Star Terminal Rating adds to the growing international recognition that Terminal 2 has garnered since its opening

Kempegowda International Airport's Terminal 2 (T2) in Bengaluru has made history by becoming the first airport terminal in India to receive the prestigious 5-Star Airport Terminal Rating from Skytrax, the renowned international air transport rating organization. This top-tier distinction recognizes an exceptionally high standard of quality and service throughout the entire passenger journey.

A Visionary Achievement in Airport Excellence

Mr. Hari Marar, MD & CEO of Bangalore International Airport Ltd (BIAL), expressed immense pride in this groundbreaking recognition. "At BLR Airport, our driving force is a singular vision: to craft a world-class travel experience that is seamless, innovative, and sustainable," Marar stated. "Becoming India's inaugural airport terminal to achieve the 5-Star Skytrax rating, alongside being named the Best Regional Airport in India and South Asia, is more than just an acknowledgment of our efforts; it's a testament to the passion and dedication of our entire team. These





Mr. Hari Marar, MD & CEO
Bangalore International Airport Ltd (BIAL)

milestones position Bengaluru firmly on the global aviation stage, and we extend our deepest gratitude to our passengers, partners, and employees for their trust and support. As we continue to push boundaries and establish new industry benchmarks, our commitment remains steadfast: to redefine airport excellence with every journey."

Terminal 2, conceptualized as a "terminal in a garden," is widely acclaimed for its architectural ambition within the region. Beyond its striking biophilic interiors and sustainable design, the terminal features a variety of unique outdoor spaces. These include serene treetop walkways, bamboo-clad viewing terraces, and, in the coming months, an elevated panoramic restaurant, all designed to offer passengers a tranquil and engaging experience.

The comprehensive evaluation by Skytrax covered all customer-facing product and service elements, encompassing arrival, departure, and transfer procedures, the range of shopping and dining options, and other crucial passenger facilities.

Mr. Edward Plaisted, CEO of Skytrax, lauded the achievement: "This 5-Star Terminal Rating marks a significant milestone for Bangalore Airport. Terminal 2 has truly set a new benchmark in India with its visionary design and unwavering commitment to quality, attaining world-class standards in passenger experience."

This coveted Skytrax 5-Star Terminal Rating adds to the growing international recognition that Terminal 2 has garnered since its opening. It firmly reaffirms its



standing as an impressively designed and executed airport infrastructure project.

As the first terminal in India to attain this level of global acclaim, Terminal 2 ushers in a new era for the airport experience—one that seamlessly blends operational efficiency with environmental consciousness and distinctive architectural design.



QATAR AIRWAYS CROWNED WORLD'S BEST AIRLINE FOR NINTH TIME AT SKYTRAX 2025 AWARDS

Singapore Airlines, Cathay Pacific, and Emirates ranked second, third and fourth positions respectively.

Qatar Airways has once again soared to the top, being named the "World's Best Airline" at the highly anticipated 2025 World Airline Awards. The prestigious announcement took place during a glittering gala ceremony at the Paris Air Show, held within the magnificent art deco Hall of Eight Columns at Le Bourget

airport's Air and Space Museum.

The event, often referred to as "the Oscars of the aviation industry," welcomed approximately 500 guests, including numerous airline Chairmen, CEOs, and Presidents from across the globe, who accepted their accolades. A familiar sight at the World Airline Awards, uniformed airline

crew proudly represented their brands, adding to the grandeur of the occasion.

The World Airline Awards, established in 1999, are renowned for their complete independence and impartiality. Skytrax, the organizers, solely bear the costs of the customer surveys and the awards event, ensuring unbiased results.



Edward Plaisted, CEO of Skytrax, commented on the evening's outcomes: "We were pleased to see a significant number of past winners return, alongside the welcome presence of new faces and airlines. The repeated recognition of many previous winning airlines clearly demonstrates that customers highly value consistent quality when casting their votes."

Engr. Badr Mohammed Al-Meer, Group CEO of Qatar Airways, expressed immense pride in the airline's remarkable achievement: "Being recognized as the World's Best Airline for an unprecedented ninth time is an extraordinary honor. This award signifies far more than just a title; it is a testament to the passion, precision, and purpose that define Qatar Airways. To maintain this distinction in an intensely competitive and constantly evolving global industry reflects the unwavering dedication across all facets of our operations, from our frontline teams to those working behind the scenes. The commitment of our people continues to set new benchmarks in aviation."

Al-Meer further highlighted the airline's additional triumphs: "We are equally proud to have been named the Best Airline in the Middle East, to once again hold the title of the World's Best Business Class, and to be recognized for offering the Best Business Class Airline Lounge experience globally. These accolades reinforce our ambition not just to lead, but to redefine what exceptional service means in aviation. Whether on the ground or in the air, we strive to deliver a seamless, elevated journey that anticipates our passengers' needs and embodies the highest standards of quality, comfort, and innovation. Our continuous recognition as a 5-Star Airline further underscores our mission: to establish new industry benchmarks and ensure our passengers feel genuinely cared for, valued, and inspired to choose us again. These awards are not merely wins for us; they are a tribute to the trust of millions of travelers who fly with us every year and a clear validation of our vision to shape the future of air travel."

Global Airline Rankings and Key Accolades

Singapore Airlines, a five-time winner of the prestigious Airline of the Year award, secured the second spot globally for 2025. Cathay Pacific Airways ascended to third place, with Emirates ranking fourth and

ANA All Nippon Airways completing the top five among over 325 airlines evaluated in the survey.

The World Top 20 Airlines in 2025 are:

Qatar Airways; Singapore Airlines; Cathay Pacific; Emirates; ANA All Nippon Airways; Turkish Airlines; Korean Air; Air France; Japan Airlines; Hainan Airlines; Swiss Int'l Air Lines; EVA Air; British Airways; Qantas Airways; Lufthansa; Virgin Atlantic; Saudi Arabian Airlines (Saudia); STARLUX Airlines; Air Canada; and Iberia

Edward Plaisted of Skytrax congratulated Qatar Airways: "It is a truly remarkable achievement for Qatar Airways to secure the World's Best Airline title for 2025, marking their ninth victory in the awards' history. Qatar Airways delivered outstanding results across numerous categories, with their Business Class earning the World's Best Business Class award, and their Al Mourjan Garden Lounge being named the World's Best Business Class Airline Lounge. We extend our warmest congratulations to Qatar Airways on these successes, which should be a tremendous source of pride for the airline's leadership and staff."

Singapore Airlines also received top honors for the "World's Best Cabin Crew," and their First Class Suites continued to impress, winning the award for the "World's Best First Class." In one of the most competitive airline service regions, Singapore Airlines also claimed the "Best Airline in Asia" accolade.

Taiwanese carrier STARLUX Airlines was awarded the "World's Most Improved Airline 2025," recognizing their significant quality enhancements across the entire awards program. Earlier in the Paris event, STARLUX Airlines also achieved a 5-Star Airline Rating for the first time, bringing the global total of 5-Star airlines to eleven.

Glenn Chai, CEO of STARLUX Airlines, who accepted the awards, remarked: "Receiving the 5-Star Airline award is an immense honor and a profound encouragement for everyone at STARLUX. Having launched operations in 2020, reaching this milestone highlights the resilience and passion of our entire team. We are incredibly thrilled and deeply grateful for the trust our passengers place in us and the unwavering dedication of our team. STARLUX will continue to expand our network and elevate our standards for safety and service, offering travelers worldwide a warm and refined

experience in the sky."

AirAsia continued its winning streak, securing the "World's Best Low-Cost Airline" award for the sixteenth consecutive year, a title it has held since 2010. Scoot was recognized as the "World's Best Long Haul Low-Cost Airline."

Mr. Tony Fernandes, CEO of Capital A and co-founder of AirAsia, expressed his astonishment: "To win the World's Best Low-Cost Airline Award for 16 years in a row is simply incredible. From flying just 200,000 guests in our first year to aiming to welcome our one billionth guest this year – this journey has been made possible by the unwavering support of our guests and the tireless dedication of our incredible Allstars. We thank the Skytrax team for acknowledging our work, and I dedicate this award to my Allstars; it truly belongs to them. Thank you for believing in the dream."

Air Transat was named the "World's Best Leisure Airline," marking its third consecutive triumph in this category. Pamela Lloyd-Bergeron, Air Transat Director In-Flight Service, commented, "Receiving this award for the seventh time and third year in a row is an honor for everyone at Air Transat. It reflects our dedication to delivering excellent service and memorable journeys for our passengers." Annick Guérard, President and Chief Executive Officer of Air Transat, added, "This recognition is a testament to the hard work and resilience of our teams. Their commitment to providing outstanding service is the reason behind our success."

Lufthansa was recognized as the "World's Most Family Friendly Airline," an award covering various family-oriented features such as seating policies, check-in facilities, priority boarding, children's meals and amenities, onboard entertainment, luggage policies for infants, and service assistance from ground and cabin crew.

Cathay Pacific received the award for the "World's Best Inflight Entertainment," surpassing Emirates (2nd) and Qatar Airways (3rd).

Saudia was honored with the "Best Airline Staff Service in the Middle East" award. H.E. Engr. Ibrahim Al-Omar, Director General of Saudia Group, commented: "This award reflects the dedication of our incredible frontline team and the trust of our guests. While we celebrate this milestone, our journey continues—with bold investments and a clear vision to become one of the world's leading airlines."

MALAYSIA AIRLINES ENHANCES BONUS SIDE TRIP FOR INTERNATIONAL TRAVELLERS

Double the Adventure and Discover More of Malaysia Ahead of Visit Malaysia Year 2026

Malaysia Airlines, in a powerful collaboration with the Malaysia Convention and Exhibition Bureau (MYCEB) and the Langkawi Development Authority (LADA), recently concluded the second annual Trade Elevation Summit (TES). Held from June 10 to 12, 2025, on the picturesque island of Langkawi, this flagship event served as a critical platform

to energize global trade partnerships and bolster Malaysia's vision for Visit Malaysia Year 2026 (VMY2026).

Uniting Global Aviation Leaders in a Stunning Setting

As Malaysia's premier airline trade gathering, TES 2025 drew over 300 delegates from 68 cities worldwide,

including airline representatives, trade partners, and key industry stakeholders. Following the success of its inaugural edition in Kuala Lumpur last year, the summit leveraged Langkawi's breathtaking UNESCO Global Geopark status to provide an inspiring backdrop for collaboration, innovation, and strategic discussions. Attendees were treated to a blend of business-to-business (B2B) sessions, immersive product showcases, and insightful forums focused on aviation growth, regional connectivity, and destination marketing, all while experiencing the rich tapestry of Malaysian culture.

Championing Langkawi and National Tourism Goals

Mr. Dersensih Aresandiran, Chief Commercial Officer for Airlines of Malaysia Aviation Group, highlighted the airline's commitment to showcasing Malaysia's diverse appeal. "Malaysia is more than just a destination; it's a narrative of vibrant culture, genuine hospitality, and global potential," Aresandiran stated. "As the national carrier, Malaysia Airlines proudly carries this story across continents, bridging nations and representing all that Malaysia embodies."



He emphasized Langkawi's enduring significance within the airline's network, noting it as one of their earliest and most cherished leisure destinations. With 56 weekly flights connecting Langkawi to key cities both within Malaysia and internationally, Malaysia Airlines continues to position the island as a crucial tourism gateway and a driver of regional economic growth.

Aresandiran further explained that hosting TES in Langkawi reflects the airline's sustained dedication to elevating Malaysia's primary tourism hubs and aligning with national objectives. He pointed to initiatives like the "Bonus Side Trip" program and ongoing investments in connectivity, product innovation, digital platforms, and customer experience as core strategies. These efforts aim to solidify Malaysia Airlines' standing as a top-of-mind carrier in the region and mark a strategic milestone leading up to Visit

Malaysia Year 2026, where the airline will continue its role as a proud champion of Malaysia as a premier global destination.

A Unified Push for Tourism Growth

As an annual initiative, TES reinforces Malaysia Airlines' mission to promote Malaysia as a preferred travel destination, foster innovation in aviation, and encourage closer collaboration between international stakeholders and local industry players. This year's summit in Langkawi not only reinforced Malaysia's position as a leading travel destination in Asia but also underscored the airline's commitment to supporting state-level tourism through strategic alignment with the nation's broader tourism goals.

The success of TES 2025, buoyed by the strong support from MYCEB and LADA, exemplifies a cohesive national effort to fortify Malaysia's tourism and aviation sectors. Driven by strategic collaboration and a shared ambition, the summit served



Mr. Dersanish Aresandiran,
Chief Commercial Officer for Airlines,
Malaysia Aviation Group

as a timely catalyst to invigorate the tourism ecosystem, forge lasting partnerships, and reaffirm Malaysia Airlines' integral role as the nation's flagbearer as the country gears up for Visit Malaysia Year 2026.



EMIRATES A350 MAKES GRAND DEBUT AT PARIS AIRSHOW 2025 AFTER 15-YEAR HIATUS

By the end of this year, the Emirates A350 fleet is projected to serve 17 destinations

Emirates, the world's largest international airline, have made a significant return to the Paris Airshow, marking its first appearance in over 15 years. The airline has showcased its newest aircraft, the Airbus A350, at the 55th International Paris Airshow, which runs June 17-19. This public unveiling highlights the A350's next-generation cabin design, cutting-edge interiors, and advanced technologies.

Attendees at Le Bourget have the

opportunity to explore Emirates' enhanced Business Class and Premium Economy cabins, as well as its sleek and spacious Economy Class.

Mr. Sir Tim Clark, President of Emirates Airline, expressed his enthusiasm: "We are delighted to be at the Paris Airshow, presenting the pinnacle of air travel on one of the most vital platforms in the aerospace exhibition calendar. Our return to France's most important aerospace event underscores Emirates' unwavering

commitment to supporting the country's aviation industry – not only through our daily operations but also through continuous investments across the entire aerospace supply chain."

Emirates currently operates 21 weekly flights to Paris, including three daily A380 services. Additionally, the airline provides a daily A380 flight to Nice and a daily A350 service to Lyon, making it the exclusive international carrier to operate an A380 into Nice Côte d'Azur Airport.

Decades of Investment and Partnership in France

For over three decades, Emirates has played a pivotal role in expanding France's aviation sector and fostering trade and tourism flows between the two nations. Key investments by Emirates in France over this period include:

Emirates' significant purchases of A350 and A380 aircraft have sustained thousands of jobs at major French aerospace companies such as Airbus, Safran, Thales, and other entities within the aerospace value chain.

Since its establishment in 1985, Emirates has invested more than €114 billion (US\$130 billion) in acquiring 254 Airbus aircraft, encompassing various models including the A300, A310, A330, A340-300, A340-500,



A380, and A350.

The airline remains a crucial client for French aerospace manufacturers, sourcing essential components like Michelin tires, Safran aircraft components and seating, and Thales avionics systems to support its vast fleet.

In 2023, Emirates announced a series of contracts with Safran, collectively valued at over €1.0 billion (US\$1.14 billion). This includes a substantial €896 million (US\$1.0 billion) agreement for the latest generation of Safran Seats for Emirates' new Airbus A350 and Boeing 777X-9 fleets, as well as its existing Boeing 777-300ER aircraft.

The airline has also committed over €322 million (US\$367.5 million) to integrate Thales' AVANT Up in-flight entertainment system into its new A350 aircraft.

Emirates SkyCargo provides vital cargo capacity to French customers with weekly rotations between Dubai World Central (DWC), Paris Charles de Gaulle (CDG), and Lyon Saint-Exupéry airports. The UAE stands as France's largest export partner in

the Middle East.

Emirates directly injects over €189 million (US\$215 million) annually into the French economy through operational expenditures such as fuel uplift, over-flight charges, inflight catering, aircraft landing and handling fees, crew layover costs, staff salaries, advertising, and sponsorship.

Notably, France is Emirates' leading global source for wine procurement, with a significant 58% of red wine consumed in Emirates' First and Business Class originating from the Bordeaux region.

A Glimpse into the Future of Flight

The Emirates A350 on display at the airshow features three spacious cabin classes: 32 next-generation lie-flat Business Class seats, 21 Premium Economy seats, and 259 generously pitched Economy Class seats.

Visitors can experience the airline's commitment to an enhanced "fly better" experience, which includes more space and storage, extra high ceilings, and wider aisles



Mr. Sir Tim Clark,
President,
Emirates Airline

across all classes. The next-generation Business Class cabin boasts a 1-2-1 seat configuration. Passengers can also look forward to the latest generation of in-flight entertainment with a cinematic viewing experience, enhanced cabin lighting, faster Wi-Fi, and improved seat ergonomics.

By the end of this year, the Emirates A350 fleet is projected to serve 17 destinations. Emirates has already taken delivery of seven A350 aircraft, with 58 more units slated to join its fleet in the coming years.



ETHIOPIAN AIRLINES EXPANDS INDIAN FOOTPRINT WITH NEW HYDERABAD SERVICE

The airlines operating over 15 weekly dedicated passenger and cargo flights to Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, and Chennai

Ethiopian Airlines, recognized as Africa's largest and one of the globe's most rapidly expanding airlines officially inaugurated its new passenger service to Hyderabad, India, today, June 16, 2025. This marks a significant step in the airline's strategy to bolster connectivity between Africa, India, and beyond, offering travelers enhanced convenience and a wider array of travel choices.

The thrice-weekly flights commenced with a lively ceremony held at Addis Ababa Bole International Airport. The event saw

the presence of high-ranking government officials, ambassadors, esteemed guests, and prominent figures from the aviation sector, all celebrating this new link.

The newly introduced flight schedule is as follows:

ET 682: Addis Ababa (ADD) to Hyderabad (HYD) – Operating on Mondays, Wednesdays, and Saturdays.

ET 683: Hyderabad (HYD) to Addis Ababa (ADD) – Operating on Tuesdays, Thursdays, and Saturdays.

During the launch event, Mr. Mesfin Tasew,

Group CEO of Ethiopian Airlines, expressed his enthusiasm for the new route: "We are delighted to introduce this new passenger service to Hyderabad, which now becomes our fifth destination in India. We are confident that this flight will not only facilitate air travel but also significantly contribute to strengthening trade and tourism links between our two regions."

Mr. Tasew further emphasized the airline's commitment to growth: "This route provides convenient passenger transport services, and Ethiopian Airlines will continue to actively seek new opportunities to expand its network within India and the broader region. As the leading carrier on the continent, renowned for its extensive connectivity and exceptional service, we are dedicated to addressing the increasing demand for air travel and fostering robust cross-border partnerships."

Prior to this launch, Ethiopian Airlines already maintained a substantial presence in India, operating over fifty weekly dedicated passenger and cargo flights to four major Indian cities: Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, and Chennai. The addition of Hyderabad to its network further solidifies Ethiopian Airlines' commitment to serving the escalating travel demand within India. This expansion offers passengers greater flexibility and seamless connections to and from India, as well as throughout the wider region.



INDIGO DOUBLES DOWN ON GLOBAL AMBITIONS WITH MASSIVE AIRBUS A350 ORDER

The airlines operating over 15 weekly dedicated passenger and cargo flights to Delhi, Mumbai, Bengaluru, and Chennai

IndiGo, India's leading airline, has solidified its path to becoming a major global aviation player by significantly expanding its wide-body aircraft order with Airbus. The airline announced it has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to convert 30 of its existing purchase rights for 70 aircraft into a firm order for Airbus A350-900s, effectively doubling its wide-body commitment from 30 to 60 firm aircraft. This strategic move marks another crucial step in IndiGo's long-term international expansion plans.

Fueling International Growth and Connectivity

This latest order builds on a pivotal decision made in April 2024, when IndiGo initially placed a firm order for 30 A350-900 aircraft, with purchase rights for an additional 70. Deliveries from that initial order are still expected to begin in 2027.

By expanding its wide-body fleet, IndiGo is poised to stretch its wings further, significantly growing its long-haul international network. This will enable the airline to connect major Indian cities with various parts of the world, offering customers a broader array of travel options to new international destinations. Crucially, this expansion will also facilitate more flights to the hubs of its partner airlines, enhancing global connectivity.

The IndiGo Airbus A350-900 aircraft will be powered by Rolls-Royce's Trent XWB engine. The combination of the aircraft's mission capability and the engine's efficiency will provide IndiGo

with unparalleled flexibility and reach as it enters the next phase of addressing the rapidly evolving needs of the Indian and global aviation markets.

In preparation for these long-haul operations, IndiGo already began introducing six temporarily leased wide-body aircraft in March 2025, with deliveries set to be completed by 2026.

Tapping into India's Aviation Boom

This ambitious fleet expansion comes

at a time when India stands as the world's third-largest aviation market. With the government's strong commitment to developing cutting-edge infrastructure and transforming the country into a global aviation hub, the opportunities for growth are immense. IndiGo's strategic investments in its wide-body fleet align perfectly with this national vision, positioning the airline to lead India's ascent on the global aviation stage.



ROYAL JORDANIAN AIRLINES UNVEILS NEW SERVICE TO MUMBAI

Hospitality industry worldwide is getting ready to adopt AI, with investment projected to grow 60% annually from 2023 to 2033.

Royal Jordanian Airlines has announced the launch of a new direct flight connecting Amman's Queen Alia International Airport (AMM) with Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport (BOM) in Mumbai. Commencing on June 19, 2025, this year-round service will operate four times a week on Mondays,

Tuesdays, Thursdays, and Fridays, utilizing a modern Airbus A320neo aircraft.

This strategic expansion aims to bolster air connectivity between India and Jordan, while also providing Indian travelers with seamless onward access to over 50 destinations across the Middle East, Gulf region, and North Africa.

Gateway to an Ancient Land

The new route is poised to unlock Jordan's extraordinary attractions for Indian tourists. With convenient direct access, travelers from Mumbai can now embark on an unforgettable journey through the Kingdom. In itineraries as short as three days or as comprehensive as





Ms. Isha Goyal, CEO,
STIC Travel Group

seven, visitors can explore the breathtaking rose-red city of Petra, one of the New Seven Wonders of the World. They can also experience floating in the therapeutic waters of the Dead Sea and discover the dramatic desert landscapes of Wadi Rum. Jordan is positioned as an authentic Arabian experience, just a five-hour flight from India, promising an enriching escape filled with natural beauty, profound culture, and renowned hospitality, whether the motivation is history, nature, or a desire for discovery.

"With direct access to Jordan, a captivating country rich in history and culture, passengers can now easily explore its inspiring landscapes," stated Mr. Karim Makhoulf, Chief Commercial Officer of Royal Jordanian. "This expansion reflects our commitment to showcasing Jordan's unique allure to tourists, inviting them to uncover its hidden gems, immerse themselves in its vibrant traditions, and experience the renowned hospitality that awaits every visitor."

A Bridge for Tourism and Trade

Royal Jordanian's new connection to Amman offers more than just enhanced convenience; it acts as a vibrant bridge between India and Jordan, linking travelers to a land where ancient marvels and modern dynamism harmoniously coexist. This launch will make it easier for Indian tourists to explore Jordan's captivating history, stunning scenery, and dynamic culture. Furthermore, Indian tourists

booking specific travel packages will be eligible for visa-free entry, simplifying their journey.

Ms. Isha Goyal, CEO of STIC Travel Group, expressed her enthusiasm for the Mumbai-Amman service, launched on June 19th. "The new direct service between Mumbai and Amman is more than just a flight - it is a bridge between two ancient civilizations and a gateway for deeper tourism, trade, and cultural exchange," she remarked. "Jordan holds a distinctive place in the Levant region, and as a longstanding friend of India, this long-awaited route marks a significant step in bringing our countries closer. This milestone reflects STIC Travel's continued commitment to forging strategic airline partnerships built on trust, shared vision, and service excellence. We look forward to introducing Indian travelers to the richness and beauty of Jordan, an inspiring and still largely untapped destination."

As a preferred airline for convenient global travel, Royal Jordanian offers travelers from Mumbai smooth connections not only to Jordan but also onward to over 50 destinations across the Middle East, Europe, North Africa, the United States, and Canada. The airline prides itself on attractive fares, well-timed schedules, and a reputation for comfort and reliability,



Mr. Karim Makhoulf,
Chief Commercial Officer,
Royal Jordanian

ensuring a streamlined travel experience across continents. As a proud member of the oneworld airline alliance since 2007, Royal Jordanian further enhances access to a global network of premium services and destinations, making international travel from India more accessible and enjoyable than ever.



HILTON STRENGTHENS MUMBAI PRESENCE WITH NEW AIRPORT HOTEL

Hilton Garden Inn Mumbai International Airport, located at Sahar Road, Andheri East, Mumbai, Maharashtra has been officially opened its door for guests

Hilton Hotels has officially launched the Hilton Garden Inn Mumbai International Airport, marking the brand's first foray into India's financial hub. This new establishment, developed in

collaboration with Fariyas Hotels & Resorts, is strategically situated in the vibrant Andheri East area, just minutes from Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport.

The 140-room hotel is designed to offer a blend of upscale comfort and the brand's signature "Brighthearted hospitality" to both business and leisure travelers. Its guest rooms are meticulously designed,





Ms. Jenny Milos, Vice President, Brand Management, Suites & Focused Service, Asia Pacific, Hilton

featuring ergonomic workspaces, luxurious bedding, and modern conveniences. The interiors reflect Mumbai's dynamic cultural essence through carefully selected artwork.

Guests can enjoy a range of amenities, including Together & Co., an all-day dining restaurant; a rooftop pool offering city views; a well-equipped fitness center; and &ToGo, a 24/7 convenience store. The hotel also boasts flexible meeting rooms and event spaces, making it suitable for corporate meetings, training sessions, and smaller social gatherings.

Located on Sahar Road in Andheri East, the Hilton Garden Inn provides convenient access to key corporate districts, entertainment zones, and popular city landmarks like Versova Beach, Juhu Beach, and the Bandra Kurla Complex.

A Strategic Move in a Dynamic Market

"The introduction of Hilton Garden Inn Mumbai International Airport enhances our footprint in one of India's most dynamic and in-demand markets," stated Zubin Saxena, Senior Vice President and Regional Head, South Asia, Hilton. He emphasized that Mumbai has consistently been a vital center for Hilton, and this new focused-service brand aims to meet the evolving needs of the city's travelers. Saxena highlighted this opening as a significant stride in Hilton's strategic expansion, bringing its renowned hospitality to a wider audience across India.

Ms. Jenny Milos, Vice President, Brand Management, Suites & Focused Service, Asia Pacific, Hilton, added, "Hilton Garden Inn is among Hilton's fastest-growing

When it comes to organizing corporate conferences, social events or Destination Weddings, Novotel Kolkata offers bespoke experiences with a seamless blend of elegance and efficiency.

global brands, crafted for travelers who prioritize comfort, convenience, and our distinct Brighthouse service. Our entry into Mumbai reaffirms our dedication to providing reliable, business-friendly stays where guests can depend on intuitive service and amenities that support both productivity and relaxation."

Partnership Focused on Excellence

Sameer Maredia, Director, Fariyas Hotels Private Limited, expressed pride in bringing the Hilton Garden Inn brand to Mumbai, recognizing the city's ongoing economic growth. "Our collaboration with Hilton embodies a shared commitment to delivering outstanding service to contemporary travelers," Maredia commented. "We are confident that this hotel will establish a new standard for dependable, upscale hospitality in the city. Mumbai's rapid growth consistently fuels demand for high-quality accommodation. With Hilton's global expertise and our profound understanding of



Mr. Zubin Saxena, Senior VP and Regional Head, South Asia, Hilton.

the local market, we are certain this hotel will cater to the evolving needs of modern travelers and set new benchmarks in service and comfort for both business and leisure guests."

The Hilton Garden Inn Mumbai International Airport participates in Hilton Honors, Hilton's acclaimed guest-loyalty program. To mark the grand opening, Hilton Honors members can avail an exclusive offer of 1,000 Bonus Honors Points per night for a minimum stay of two nights.



IHG HOTELS & RESORTS

CELEBRATES 50TH HOTEL OPENING IN INDIA

WITH CROWNE PLAZA LUCKNOW DEBUT

The hotel features 110 well-appointed rooms and an expansive 40,000 sq. ft. of meeting and event spaces

IHG Hotels & Resorts has reached a significant milestone in India with the inauguration of Crowne Plaza Lucknow, marking its 50th operational hotel in the country. This achievement underscores IHG's long-standing commitment to the Indian market, driven by robust domestic

demand and a growing preference for world-class hospitality.

The opening of Crowne Plaza Lucknow strengthens IHG's premium offerings in India and signals continued momentum for the Crowne Plaza brand, which caters to modern business and leisure

travelers seeking a harmonious blend of productivity and comfort. Since its inception as the first business-class hotel in 1983, Crowne Plaza has consistently pioneered innovation in hospitality. The brand continuously evolves to meet the changing needs of global travelers, with



innovations ranging from enhanced guest room zoning to reimagined Meetings & Events spaces, all reflecting a modern design and guest experience.

Strategically located along the Lucknow-Sultanpur Road, with convenient access to Shahid Path, the new IT hub, and the local cricket stadium, Crowne Plaza Lucknow promises an elevated stay for both business and leisure guests. The hotel features 110 well-appointed rooms and an expansive 40,000 sq. ft. of meeting and event spaces, making it an exceptional venue for social events and MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions). Additional amenities include an all-day dining restaurant, a bar, a club lounge, a gymnasium, and an outdoor pool, positioning it as an ideal destination for conferences, weddings, and upscale city getaways.

With a diverse brand portfolio and a strong development pipeline, IHG continues to expand its presence across key business and leisure destinations in India, solidifying its position as one of the nation's fastest-growing hospitality brands.

Mr. Haitham Mattar, Managing Director, MEA & Southwest Asia, IHG Hotels & Resorts, expressed his enthusiasm: "We are thrilled to open our 50th hotel in India. This is a significant milestone that reflects our deep commitment to the country and our confidence in its vibrant travel and hospitality landscape. India remains one of our most strategic markets globally, and we are excited about the opportunities it presents as we continue to introduce our diverse portfolio of brands to more locations. While mainstream brands such as Holiday Inn, Holiday Inn Express, and Garner remain our primary growth drivers in the country, we are also strengthening our premium and luxury portfolio with iconic and well-established brands like Crowne Plaza, InterContinental, and Six Senses."

Mattar added, "IHG has a proven track record of delivering strong returns for our owners – in addition to guest satisfaction, owner returns continue to remain a top priority for us in India."

Mr. Sudeep Jain, Managing Director, South West Asia, IHG Hotels & Resorts, echoed these sentiments: "Achieving the 50-hotel milestone in India is a proud

moment for us. The opening of Crowne Plaza Lucknow further reinforces the relevance and strength of the Crowne Plaza brand in this market. This opening represents more than just a number; it signifies IHG's deep-rooted ambitions and robust pipeline in the country. We are committed to accelerating our expansion across brand segments, with several more hotels in the pipeline this year. Our goal is to deepen our presence in high-growth cities and deliver exceptional hospitality experiences across all segments, from mainstream, premium to luxury for both domestic and international guests."

Future Growth and "Blended Travel" Focus

IHG continues to demonstrate strong development momentum in India, having signed 18 new hotels across its brand portfolio in 2024. Nearly 30% of these new signings were in the premium and luxury segments within India. With almost 70 hotels currently in the pipeline, IHG aims to more than double its portfolio in India over the next five years, capitalizing on the country's rapidly growing travel demand and rising domestic tourism. The current pipeline includes a significant mix of luxury and premium hotels, with five InterContinental properties, ten Crowne Plaza hotels, and five voco hotels slated to open in the next 2-5 years.

Earlier this year, Crowne Plaza released



Mr. Haitham Mattar,
Managing Director,
MEA & Southwest Asia,
IHG Hotels & Resorts,

its second white paper, "Leading the Charge in Blended Travel," which highlighted a significant shift in traveler preferences towards integrating work and leisure. The study identified four emerging trends: Improve and Grow, Mind-Body Equity, The New Personal Travel Economy, and Intentional Togetherness. Notably, the research revealed that 33% of Indian travelers have already experienced blended travel, the highest percentage among surveyed countries, indicating India's leadership in this evolving travel landscape.

The launch of Crowne Plaza Lucknow directly aligns with these insights, offering facilities and services designed to cater to the modern traveler seeking comfort, world-class service, and the benefits of the IHG One Rewards loyalty program.



TGI HOTELS & RESORTS

UNVEILS TGI SPS GRAND, BOLSTERING PRESENCE IN COIMBATORE



TGI Hotels & Resorts has announced the grand opening of TGI SPS Grand, its second property in Coimbatore.

Located in the bustling Ram Nagar area, the new hotel aims to provide a blend of comfort, affordability, and exceptional hospitality to both business and leisure travelers.

The launch of TGI SPS Grand follows the successful operation of Fressotel Seetharam, marking another significant expansion for TGI in Tamil Nadu. The hotel features 53 well-appointed luxury rooms designed to cater to diverse travel needs.

"Coimbatore has always been a key market for us," said Mr. Amit Kumar, Chief Marketing Officer at TGI Hotels. "With the launch of TGI SPS Grand, we aim to elevate the hospitality experience for travelers and further strengthen our commitment to this vibrant city."

TGI SPS Grand offers a comprehensive range of amenities to ensure a seamless stay for its guests. These include the Silver Oak Restaurant, serving a multi-cuisine spread, and Shooters Bar, an ideal spot for unwinding. The hotel also provides modern amenities and conference spaces, aiming to meet all guest requirements under one roof.

The hotel emphasizes warm, personalized service and smart pricing, positioning itself as a prime choice for those visiting Coimbatore for business or a weekend getaway.

To celebrate its opening, TGI SPS Grand is offering exciting launch offers and exclusive packages. Reservations can be made by visiting www.tgihotels.com or by calling 1800 258 3100.



ITC HOTELS SIGNS WELCOMHOTEL VRINDAVAN

Brand Welcomhotel to grow presence in Uttar Pradesh with 120 keys hotel

ITC Hotels Limited (ITCHL) has announced the signing of a new Welcomhotel in Vrindavan, Uttar Pradesh with M/s. KD Greens, Mathura. This marks the entry of Brand Welcomhotel to an important market and further strengthens the ITCHL footprint in Uttar Pradesh with the existing six operating hotels offering 479 keys and more properties across brands in the pipeline.

Spread across 3 acres, 'Welcomhotel by ITC Hotels Vrindavan' will feature 120 guest rooms along with large banqueting space, an all-day dining, a speciality restaurant, swimming pool, spa & kids club.

Located 90 km from the Noida International Airport, on Delhi Agra Highway – NH-19, Welcomhotel by ITC Hotels Vrindavan will have excellent connectivity from Delhi National Capital Region and the cities of Agra, Mathura and Lucknow.

Mr. Anil Chadha, Managing Director, ITC Hotels said, "India's pilgrimage tourism has witnessed a big upswing. Travellers are seeking meaning-driven journeys, spaces of reflection and connections with heritage and self. As the country witnesses a surge in domestic travel with cultural pride, spiritual destinations have become vibrant tourism hubs, driving footfall and economic opportunity across various cities and heritage sites. We recognise this growing demand. Welcomhotel Vrindavan shall reflect the legacy of this sacred town."

Mr. Narendra Kumar Agrawal, Partner, KD Greens said, "We are delighted to

have entered into an agreement for Welcomhotel by ITC Hotels Vrindavan with ITC Hotels Limited. We are confident this association will contribute to the growing landscape of the cities of Vrindavan and

Mathura. Destinations such as Goverdhan, Barsana and Gokul also add to the charm of these cities, making the hotel an ideal choice for religious tourism and wedding destinations."



IHCL UNVEILS CORAL PEARL, LAKSHADWEEP A NEW GEM IN THE ARABIAN SEA

Coral Pearl, Lakshadweep features 50 opulent glamping tents, each designed as a personal haven of comfort equipped with modern amenities.

Indian Hotels Company (IHCL) has announced the launch of Coral Pearl, Lakshadweep - IHCL SeleQtions, marking a significant new addition to the pristine Lakshadweep archipelago.

Embracing Island Serenity

"The opening of Coral Pearl on Bangaram Island extends an invitation to travelers

to discover the unparalleled beauty of Lakshadweep, truly one of India's most unspoiled island retreats," stated Mr. Prabhat Verma, Executive Vice President - Operations, IHCL. "As a part of the IHCL SeleQtions brand, this new hotel exemplifies our dedication to providing distinctive experiences that are deeply rooted in the essence of the local environment."

Luxurious Comfort Amidst Nature

Coral Pearl, Lakshadweep - IHCL SeleQtions, features 50 opulent glamping tents, each designed as a personal haven of comfort equipped with modern amenities. Guests will enjoy expansive glass panels that offer breathtaking panoramic views of the Arabian Sea, allowing them to witness





the mesmerizing interplay of colors across the horizon. The interiors, decorated with subtle hues and natural textures, cultivate a warm and inviting ambiance, creating a sense of home amidst the island's exotic natural splendor.

Culinary Delights and Aquatic Adventures

Guests can embark on a delightful culinary journey at Smok, the all-day dining restaurant. Its carefully curated menu features a selection of contemporary Indian, Continental, and Asian cuisines. For those looking to unwind, Calypso, the vibrant bar, draws inspiration from the deep-sea legends of Lakshadweep. As a gateway to marine wonders, the island encourages adventure enthusiasts to explore its rich biodiversity through activities like scuba diving, snorkeling, kayaking, and specially organized nature trails.

"Coral Pearl, Lakshadweep - IHCL SeleQtions, is conceived as an immersive experience where luxury harmonizes with the natural rhythm of island life," commented Ms. Kashish Singh, General Manager of Coral Pearl, Lakshadweep - IHCL SeleQtions. "From rich local cuisine to the untouched natural beauty, guests are invited to both relax and actively explore the destination."

Set in the heart of the Arabian Sea, Bangaram Island is truly a hidden treasure, boasting soft sandy beaches, gracefully swaying palm trees, and crystal-clear waters teeming with marine life, making it an irresistible escape into nature for travellers.

TAJ MAKES GRAND DEBUT IN SOUTH AFRICA'S

Three Luxury Safari Lodges near Kruger National Park

The Indian Hotels Company (IHCL), India's largest hospitality firm, has officially announced its foray into the luxury wildlife hospitality sector in South Africa with the signing of three exclusive lodges under its iconic Taj brand. These properties will be nestled within the pristine Balule Game Reserve, a vital part of the renowned Kruger National Park.

A New Chapter in Purpose-Led Travel

"As the demand for purpose-led travel continues its upward trajectory, Taj is uniquely positioned to deliver exceptional safari experiences," stated Mr. Puneet Chhatwal, Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer, IHCL. "Our differentiated offerings seamlessly combine expert-led jungle drives with meaningful community engagement and conservation-focused design, curating truly unforgettable journeys. Our expansion into Kruger National Park builds upon this rich legacy, promising travelers an authentic connection with nature through a responsible tourism approach. We are thrilled to collaborate with OM USA LLC to transform this vision into reality."

Unparalleled Wilderness Experiences

The three new luxury lodges promise an elevated safari experience amidst the African wilderness. These include the 30-key Taj Lion Kings Hilltop Tented Camp, the more intimate 6-key Taj Lion Kings Bush Lodge, and the serene 6-key Taj Lion Kings River Lodge. Each lodge will feature an all-day dining restaurant, a rejuvenating spa, a swimming pool, and dedicated recreation areas, expertly blending comfort with the raw authenticity of the African wild.

Mr. Manish Patel of OM USA LLC expressed his enthusiasm for the

partnership, remarking, "The tightly controlled environment of the Balule Game Reserve guarantees exclusivity and privacy, making it a perfect destination for discerning global explorers. Taj has held a special place in the hearts of wildlife enthusiasts and nature lovers for over two decades. We are delighted to partner with India's largest hospitality ecosystem to introduce the legendary Taj brand to Kruger National Park."

Kruger National Park, spanning nearly 20,000 square kilometers, stands as one of the world's most celebrated wildlife reserves. It is famously home to the "Big Five" - lion, leopard, elephant, rhinoceros, and buffalo. Located within the Greater Kruger zone, the Balule Game Reserve offers the same rich wildlife experience, characterized by unfenced borders that allow animals to roam freely. Unique to this reserve, off-road game drives and thrilling night safaris facilitate rare and intimate encounters with wildlife.

OM USA LLC, founded by Ms. Adity Patel and Mr. Manish Patel, is a New York-based entity primarily specializing in the trading of diamonds, colored gemstones, and fine jewelry. The company meticulously sources and crafts high-quality diamonds and jewelry, leveraging state-of-the-art processing facilities in both India and the US to create distinctive designs for luxury retailers. Beyond its core jewelry business, OM USA LLC holds diversified interests in real estate holdings and leasing across the US and India. Notably, founders Adity and Manish Patel share a profound passion for wildlife conservation, adding a meaningful dimension to this collaboration.

XANDARI RESORTS

25 YEARS OF PIONEERING ECO-LUXURY IN KERALA

Xandari's quarter-century journey has established it as a global benchmark for conservation-focused tourism

Xandari Resorts, the hospitality brand of the Muthoot Group, is proud to celebrate 25 years of leading eco-luxury tourism in Kerala. As global awareness of sustainability and climate responsibility grows, Xandari's unique fusion of high-end hospitality and environmental stewardship has redefined modern luxury.

Xandari's quarter-century journey has established it as a global benchmark for conservation-focused tourism. The brand is deeply committed to community partnerships and crafting immersive, authentic traveler experiences. This dedication is evident across its three distinctive resorts in Kerala, all sharing a vision of environmental protection and local

engagement: Cardamom County by Xandari near the Periyar Tiger Reserve in Thekkady; Xandari Riverscapes in Alappuzha, set on the expansive Vembanad Lake; and Xandari Pearl Beach Resort in Marari, located along the stunning Mararikulam shoreline.

Notably, Xandari also established Kerala's first ISO-certified 4-star resort and holds the TOFTigers Pug-Eco Rated certification. The PUG (Practices Under Guidelines) certification, awarded by TOFTigers, is a green labeling system that recognizes resorts for their sustainable operating practices, further underscoring Xandari's commitment to high standards. This dedication to sustainability aligns with global best practices, exemplified by Xandari Resort and Spa in Costa Rica - a 40-acre plantation that holds the Elite level CST certification, the highest level of Costa Rica's Certification for Sustainable Tourism (CST) program. This highlights Xandari's proactive approach to integrating international standards into its operations in Kerala.

"As we celebrate this significant milestone, we view Xandari not merely as a hospitality brand, but as a platform where ideas, cultures, and traditions converge," said Mr. George M. George, Managing Director, Xandari Resorts. "Our philosophy is rooted in fostering meaningful exchanges between the local community, our dedicated team of 'Xandarians,' and global





Mr. George M. George,
Managing Director,
Xandari Resorts

travelers. True travel experiences extend beyond sightseeing - they encompass culture, heritage, food, history, and ethics."

Mr. George added, "The Xandari portfolio of resorts, strategically located across Kerala's distinct ecosystems of forest, backwaters, and beach, truly



captures the essence of the region. For a comprehensive and authentic experience of 'God's Own Country's' diverse natural landscapes, Xandari stands as the premier choice. We strive to foster these enriching interactions, ensuring every journey leaves a lasting impact on both our travelers and the communities we serve."

Over the years, Xandari has consistently set benchmarks in sustainable tourism. Initiatives include a complete ban on single-use plastics across all its resorts,

the installation of EV charging stations for eco-conscious travelers, and the adoption of solar energy, which now powers the majority of its operations. Beyond environmental sustainability, Xandari strongly champions local farming and artisan communities. This ensures that every traveler experience is both enriching and responsible, contributing to the local economy - as the majority of employees are from the local community - and preserving Kerala's cultural heritage.



UDS GROUP OF HOTELS EXPANDS TO KOCHI WITH UDAY SUITES - AIRPORT APARTMENT HOTEL

The rebranded property, Uday Suites Kochi, will feature 58 spacious, centrally air-conditioned suite rooms

The UDS Group of Hotels has officially announced its entry into Kerala's commercial capital with the launch of Uday Suites Kochi, an airport apartment hotel located directly opposite Cochin International Airport.

The renowned UDS Group of Hotels is set to make its mark on Kochi's hospitality landscape with the launch of Uday Suites, a premier airport apartment hotel. The group has acquired the former Lotus 8 hotel, a well-known property and one of Kerala's earliest airport hotels, situated directly across from Cochin International Airport.



This strategic expansion was formalized in a handover ceremony attended by Mr. Rajasekharan Nair, Chairman and Managing Director of UDS Group; Mrs. Radha Nair, Director; Mr. Vignesh Nair, Executive Director; Mr. Mohankumaran Nair, Director - Finance; and Mr. Raj Gopaal Iyer, CEO of UDS Group of Hotels.

Mr. Rajasekharan Nair, Chairman and Managing Director of UDS Group, expressed his enthusiasm for the new venture. "We are thrilled to bring the UDS experience to the vibrant city of Kochi," he stated. "Uday Suites will cater to the needs of discerning travelers with its modern amenities and strategic location."

The hotel will undergo a complete rebranding to become Uday Suites Kochi and will feature 58 fully-equipped spacious suite rooms and a comprehensive range of facilities, including a multi-cuisine restaurant, bar, conference hall, boardroom, business center, and health club. The rebranded property - Uday Suites Cochin - features 58 centrally air-conditioned suite rooms designed for comfort and convenience. The hotel is equipped with modern amenities including multi-cuisine restaurants, a bar, conference and board rooms, a business centre, health club, travel desk, and a kids' activity zone, making it an ideal choice for both business and leisure travelers.

The rebranded property, Uday Suites Kochi, will feature 58 spacious, centrally



UDS GROUP LAUNCHES UDS ACADEMY FOR EDUCATION

A Landmark Entry into Hospitality & Aviation Training

UDS Group of Hotels launched its first professional education venture UDS Academy for Education (UAE) a pioneering institution dedicated to excellence in hospitality and aviation training. The inaugural ceremony was held at the prestigious Travancore Bank Officers Educational Society (TRABOES), Trivandrum.

Rooted in a decades-long legacy of hospitality excellence, this visionary initiative marks UDS Group's bold foray into the education sector. UDS Academy is designed to bridge the gap between industry expectations and the capabilities of emerging talent, offering a carefully curated curriculum, state-of-the-art infrastructure, and mentorship from industry veterans.

The Academy's mission is not just to educate, but to nurture professionals who exude confidence, character, and competence future leaders poised to elevate the standards of service and professionalism across the hospitality and aviation sectors, both in India and globally.

Speaking at the inauguration, Mr. Rajasekharan Nair, Chairman and Managing Director of UDS Group, emphasized the group's unwavering commitment to shaping future-ready professionals.

"The launch of UDS Academy is not just a milestone it is a promise to the industry, students, and to the legacy of UDS: that we will continue to invest in the future with the same passion, vision, and purpose that defines everything we do".

He was joined by family members, senior UDS officials, and a distinguished gathering of hoteliers, travel agents, airline association representatives, and SBI officers, all of whom graced the event and extended their support.



air-conditioned suite rooms. The hotel is equipped with a comprehensive range of modern amenities, including a multi-cuisine restaurant, a bar, a conference hall, a boardroom, a business center, a health club, a travel desk, and a kids' activity zone.

The hotel's prime location offers

unparalleled convenience, providing a strong value proposition for business travelers, transit guests, and corporate clients. This move complements the UDS Group's existing airport property, Uday Suites Shanghumugham in Trivandrum, which also operates a successful flight

catering division under the brand Uday Sky Kitchen.

With this latest addition, the UDS Group of Hotels reinforces its presence in Kerala's fast-growing airport hospitality segment and continues its commitment to delivering excellence in service and guest experience.

WGH HOTELS & RESORTS UNVEILS FLAGSHIP KOCHI PROJECT

The World Group established its presence in Kerala's tourism and hospitality sector in 2012 with the acquisition of World Backwaters Alleppey

WGH Hotels & Resorts Pvt. Ltd., the hospitality arm of the diversified World Group based at Odisha, recently hosted Mr. P. Rajeev, Minister for Industry, Government of Kerala, at the site of its upcoming five-star hotel project near Cochin International Airport. This visit underscored the significance of the luxury development, which was a highlight at the recent Kerala Global Investment

Meet, aligning with the state's vision for sustainable and experience-driven tourism.

In a significant announcement made during the visit, the World Group revealed plans for an integrated project that includes both the new luxury hotel and a world-class hospitality college. This ambitious venture, with a proposed investment of ₹250 crore, is projected to create 1,050 job opportunities for Kerala's youth, equipping

them with skills for global hospitality careers. The project, spanning 1.75 lakh square feet, will feature 120 state-of-the-art rooms, six premium food and beverage outlets, and modern conference facilities. Completion is anticipated within two and a half years.

The World Group established its presence in Kerala's tourism and hospitality sector in 2012 with the acquisition of



Mr. J. Jayakrishnan, Director of World Group and WGH Hotels & Resorts handing over a memento to Mr. P. Rajeev, Minister for Industry, Government of Kerala



World Backwaters Alleppey. Today, World Group Heritance (WGH) owns and operates distinctive properties across prominent destinations such as Alleppey, Munnar, and Thekkady in "God's Own Country." The group is now making bold strides with new developments planned for Kochi, Varkala, Trivandrum, and Ashtamudi - including an exclusive wellness resort. Each property is designed to international standards while being deeply rooted in Kerala's rich cultural heritage.

During the site visit, Minister Rajeev was presented with the master plan and design philosophy for the WGH Kochi project, which is scheduled to launch on January 1, 2028. This luxury destination aims to set new benchmarks in hospitality by seamlessly combining modern infrastructure with authentic Kerala experiences.

Mr. P. Rajeev, Minister for Industries & Commerce, Government of Kerala, commented, "The Invest Kerala Global Summit is poised to transform the industrial and investment landscape of our state. We are delighted to announce that the Odisha-based World Group, which expressed keen interest during the summit, has now committed to investing ₹500 crore in Kerala's hospitality sector over the next five years."

He continued, "I have personally inspected and reviewed the Odisha-based WGH Hotels & Resorts' upcoming five-star hotel project at Nedumbassery, Kochi, which was initially announced during the Invest Kerala Summit held at Kochi early

this year. This initiative reflects the strong confidence global hospitality brands have in Kerala's robust and investor-friendly environment. Kerala already holds the distinction of having the highest number of five-star hotels in the country, and the upcoming WGH project is set to further strengthen this position."

Mr. J. Jayakrishnan, Director of World Group and WGH Hotels & Resorts, expressed his gratitude for the government's unwavering support and its investment-friendly policies. "Kerala's infrastructure

development and progressive tourism policies are perfectly aligned with our vision. Our projects aim to promote responsible and sustainable tourism while providing guests with an immersive experience of Kerala's unique lifestyle and traditions," said Mr. Jayakrishnan. He further emphasized that WGH Hotels & Resorts remains committed to supporting Kerala's journey toward becoming a global tourism hub, firmly rooted in the values of sustainability, cultural integrity, and community empowerment.

The World Group, with nearly four decades of entrepreneurial legacy that began in mining and has expanded into sectors such as DRI, retail, logistics, agriculture, and consulting, has invested INR 250 crores in Kerala's hospitality sector over the past two years. The group has committed an additional INR 500 crores for upcoming ventures, which include the new resort projects, the world-class hospitality college in Kochi, and a chain of vegetarian restaurants across the state.

The proposed hospitality college is envisioned to nurture approximately 200 professionals annually, fostering local talent and elevating the industry's global standards. The Varkala and Ashtamudi resorts are slated to open their doors to guests by 2027, positioning WGH as a key player in Kerala's future tourism ecosystem.



DEEPIKA ARORA

CRAFTING SOULFUL LUXURY FOR A NEW INDIA

As the Head of Dusit Hotels & Resorts, India, and the founder of boutique hospitality brand Rosastays, Deepika Arora stands at the unique intersection of entrepreneurship, brand building, and heartfelt hospitality. We caught up with the dynamic industry leader for a candid conversation about her vision for Dusit's India expansion, the future of wellness travel, and why thoughtful luxury is the new benchmark.

You've led global brands like Hilton and Wyndham. Now, you're spearheading Dusit's India comeback. What's exciting about this chapter?

"Dusit's re-entry into India isn't just about adding hotels - it's about reimagining luxury with Asian sensibility," says Deepika, her eyes lighting up with enthusiasm. "We're bringing in a hospitality model rooted in graciousness, wellness, and deep cultural connection - something I believe modern Indian travellers are truly ready for."

What attracted you to Dusit and its brand philosophy?

"It was the soul of the brand," she says without hesitation. "Dusit doesn't chase opulence for the sake of it. It's about purpose, grace, and authenticity. In India's premium space, that emotional depth gives us a distinct edge."

How do you balance Dusit's global identity with India's local flavours and expectations?

"Cultural agility is key. While our Thai roots guide us, our Indian footprint is crafted with local narratives - right from architecture and cuisine to wellness programs. We don't transplant Thailand into India - we co-create with our surroundings."

Dusit launched in the Indian Himalayas - a bold and intentional choice. What drove that decision?

"The Himalayas embody everything Dusit stands for - introspection, serenity, spiritual connection. Post-pandemic, travellers are craving meaningful, wellness-driven experiences. Launching in places like Dhulikhel, Kathmandu, and now Shimla with



dusitD2 Fagu was a natural fit. And we're just getting started - with new properties coming up in Kasol and Manali."

How is Dusit's Thai-inspired service being reimagined for Indian sensibilities?

"Indian and Thai hospitality share a deep emotional core - warmth, intuition, respect. We take that common ground and elevate it with Indian flavours, rituals, and cultural touchpoints. It's not duplication - it's a soulful fusion."

What changes are you seeing in traveller expectations post-COVID, and how is Dusit adapting?

"People want depth, not just décor. At Dusit, we're curating experiences that heal and connect - from mindful design and community-led wellness to farm-to-fork dining. Luxury today is personal and purposeful."

You often speak of "luxury with purpose." What does that look like in practice?

"It's about conscious indulgence," she explains. "At dusitD2 Fagu, we use local materials, run zero-waste kitchens, and hire regional talent. Every decision supports sustainability, community, and cultural continuity."

What kind of local partnerships are helping embed authenticity in Dusit India properties?

"Authenticity can't be outsourced - it has to be co-created. We collaborate with artisans, wellness practitioners, and local designers to craft a sense of place. From Himalayan botanicals to regional textiles, every detail matters."

You're also the founder of Rosastays. How do you balance your entrepreneurial venture with Dusit's corporate growth?

"Rosastays keeps me grounded," Deepika smiles. "It's where I see firsthand what today's Indian traveller truly wants - authenticity, storytelling, flexibility. I bring those insights into my work with Dusit, making both roles mutually enriching."

What key lessons from Rosastays have you applied to Dusit's India strategy?

"The power of emotional memory. At Rosastays, we create experiences around stories. At Dusit, we're scaling that principle - ensuring each stay is not just luxurious, but unforgettable."

As a woman leader in hospitality, what have been your most defining moments?

"Setting up operations in remote regions. Sitting across boardrooms where you're the only woman. Each challenge has sharpened my empathy and resilience. I lead with people, purpose, and performance in equal measure."

Do you see more collaboration between boutique ventures and global brands in India's hospitality future?

"Absolutely. Global brands offer structure and scale; boutique ventures bring agility and cultural nuance. Together, they can deliver experiences that are layered, rich, and future-forward."

What trends will shape premium and wellness travel in India over the next five years?

"Slow travel. Soulful travel. We'll see more demand for forest bathing, Ayurvedic



healing, nature-immersive retreats, and spiritual reconnection. The new luxury is about equilibrium, not excess."

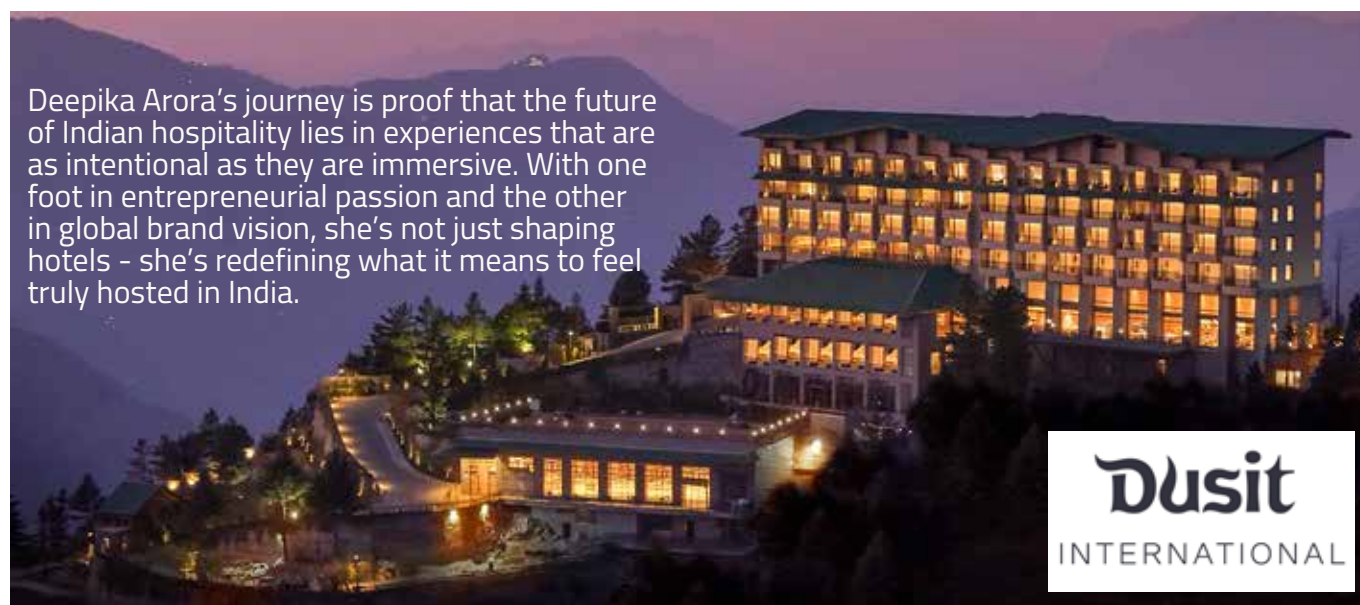
What's the roadmap for Dusit in India?

"We're focused on experiential and culturally rich destinations - Shimla, Kasol, Manali, Sakleshpur. Each property is curated, not commoditized. We're also entering emerging cities like Raipur, Bhiwadi, Lonavala, and Kolkata."

"From ultra-luxury retreats like Devarana Sakleshpur to upper midscale offerings, our aim is not just expansion - it's emotional resonance."

What legacy do you hope to leave behind?

"I want Indian hospitality to stand for soulful luxury - globally respected, locally rooted. Through Dusit and Rosastays, I hope to build brands that offer more than service - they offer meaning."



Deepika Arora's journey is proof that the future of Indian hospitality lies in experiences that are as intentional as they are immersive. With one foot in entrepreneurial passion and the other in global brand vision, she's not just shaping hotels - she's redefining what it means to feel truly hosted in India.

SAROVAR PORTICO KOLKATA RAJARHAT KOLKATA'S NEWEST HOSPITALITY GEM

For business and leisure travellers on a visit to the city and in quest of personalized experience along with a memorable culinary journey, Sarovar Portico Kolkata Rajarhat - the city's newest four-star property is the ideal choice. The food court, Golpo showcases the culinary heritage of Bengal and Kolkata that is quite diverse with Chinese, Mughal, British and Marwari flavours.

For travel buffs and gourmet lovers looking ahead for a novel culinary experience in a dose of serenity along with cosy comfort, there's Sarovar Portico Kolkata Rajarhat, Tucked away in the Central Business District (CBD) of New Town-Rajarhat area, the upscale,

15-storied hospitality set-up opened its doors sometime on November 24, last year. Owned by the Jain Group and managed by Sarovar Hotels, the property is emerging popular among travellers and diners since inception.

It was a rare privilege for me to receive

24-hour staycation at this newly-opened property in early June, this year. The luxury hospitality provider is well-gear'd with 128 keys. After stepping into the property, I checked into one of those suites offered to me on the 10th floor. Equipped with two bedrooms, a living room and a kitchen, the suites are quite spacious and cosy. The upscale property is spread over 70,000 sq. ft area and has a banquet occupying an area of over 800 sq. ft. There's Golpo, the all-day dining food outlet that implies conversation over food and guests gather to interact sharing anecdotes. The 100-seater cheery outlet has a refreshing ambience and offers a vibrant culinary experience that remains etched in the minds of diners.

It was past 2 PM and we began to feel our hunger pangs. Soon we came down on the ground floor and took our seats at Golpo for a sumptuous a la carte lunch. I began with a refreshing drink- Gondhoraj Ghol or buttermilk flavoured with "King of Lemons". To begin with there were starters like Spring Rolls, Lotus Stem and Kolkata Cutlet that were served with condiments. For non-vegetarians, Prawn Cutlet and Diamond Fish Fry Burger were served. The main course had Kaju Kismis Pulau





Mr. Kenneth Scott,
General Manager,
Sarovar Portico Kolkata

to be savoured with Baingan Sundari and Jhuri Aloo Bhaja. There were innumerable platters including Sona Moong Dal, Aloo Posta, Dhokar Dalna or Dhokla and chef's signature dish- Paneer Paturi that certainly deserves mention. A festive Bengali delicacy, Paneer Paturi is cooked in banana leaf covering with a thick mustard paste. To round off the meal, we had Baked Rasgulla. The lunch served at Golpo captures the essence of Bengali cuisine in every bite. Hence one gets to explore Bengali cuisine through iconic dishes. Lunch is on from 12.00 PM to 3.00 PM. and soon we made our way into our room for the evening nap.

After dozing off for a couple of hours, I geared up for dinner. The buffet dinner spread out at Golpo comprised an indulgent selection of dishes like appetisers and desserts. The salad section was quite extensive with dishes like green salad, fruit salad, Papri Chaat, Khimchi, Devil Egg Salad and Raita. I started off with Cream of Spinach Soup and savoured Vegetable Spring Roll and the spicy Rajma Tikka that was quite unique. I preferred to have Punjabi dishes in the main course with Masala Kulcha that goes down well with Achari Baingan, Paneer Lababdar and Aloo Methi. Having said this, there was



Vegetarian Mongolian Noodles. Most of the dishes were appetising. At the end, I gave in to the temptation for having desserts like Gulab Jamun, Chocolate Pastry and Vanilla Pastry.

Dinner is from 7.30 PM to 10.30 PM and the buffet charges are Rs 1,199 for an adult exclusive of taxes.

The next day early morning, I captured some good views of the property and geared up for the buffet breakfast that is on from 7.30 AM to 10.30 AM. The buffet breakfast was quite comprehensive with both South Indian and North Indian platters dominating the table. As usual, I decided to

sample Idli and Masala Dosa with Sambhar and Chutney. Add to these, there were other delights like Medu Vada and Vermicelli Upma. Diners also had the choice to pick up Daliya, Poori with Aloo Methi ki Subzi and the Rajasthani Khasta Kachori and Phirni. The beverage and bakery section had Croissants, tea cakes and Muffins. Besides, there were other options like juice section, fruits and flavoured yogurt. Hence it is a novel experience for diners. The breakfast is pegged at Rs 499 per person plus taxes.

According to Kenneth Scott, General Manager, Sarovar Portico Kolkata, "Our property is incidentally the third venture of





Sarovar Hotels in the Eastern region next to Siliguri and Ranchi. Our hotel is in the midst of CBD and is at a proximal distance from the Information Technology hub and Fin Tech. It is at a distance of 11 km from Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose International Airport. The New Town area has emerged as a corporate hub in Kolkata. Being an upscale business hotel, our strategy lies in attracting the business class of travellers. Very soon, we will roll out our gym sometime in June, this year. We are planning to come up with a bar in the next six months. We are also looking ahead to set up a banquet hall spanning 2,200 sq. ft area within a period of six months.” As of now, Sarovar Hotels has 140 operational hotels in the mid-market, budget and five-star category across the country. The key feeder markets of the hospitality player are New Delhi- NCR, Bengaluru, Mumbai, Hyderabad and Ahmedabad.

The hospitality giant is spread over 85 destinations in India, Nepal and Africa. Scott explained, “During pre-pandemic times, Sarovar Hotels had a tie-up with Peerless Inn Group. The tie-up period came to an end in 2017 and since Sarovar Hotels intended to venture out in the city once again, it teamed up with Jain Group. Our remarkable feature forms our location and our hotel is at a distance of 2 km from Biswa Bangla

Convention Centre. The Coffee House menu on offer at Golpo entices the younger generation. Our hotel is at a proximal distance to the multitude of sights like Eco Town, Rabindra Tirtha, Nazrul Tirtha, Vivek Tirtha or Ramakrishna Mission Centre for

Human Excellence and Social Sciences and Mother’s Wax Museum. With generations X, Y and Z preferring sustainability, our hotel prides in its sustainability factor.”

The property is committed to sustainability and responsible hospitality. “We strive to reduce our environmental impact making use of energy-efficient systems, eco-friendly amenities and thoughtful resource management. Our journey towards sustainability is a continuous process and we are actively exploring novel ways to enhance our green initiatives like integration of solar energy, advanced waste segregation and recycling and use of biodegradable products in our hotel. Plans are on to minimise single-use plastic materials and increase digital solutions in order to reduce paper usage,” informed Scott.

So where does the property stand in the hospitality scene of the city two years down the line. “Our property will be more established and the business hub will prosper with other hotels coming up two years on. We are eyeing occupancy of 58 per cent in the first year and our occupancy level would cross 70 per cent in the next couple of years,” quipped Kenneth Scott.



RADISSON HOTELS AND AIR INDIA HOST FAM TRIP

Showcasing Premier South India Properties

Air India, in collaboration with Radisson Hotel Group showcased Radisson Blu Hotel & Suites GRT Chennai, Radisson Blu Resort Temple Bay Mamallapuram, and Radisson Resort Pondicherry Bay, by hosting an exclusive FAM trip for leading corporates from Delhi.

In a step towards future-ready hospitality, Radisson hotels has showcased their Green Meetings initiative across three iconic properties: Radisson Blu Hotel & Suites GRT Chennai, Radisson Blu Resort Temple Bay Mamallapuram, and Radisson Resort Pondicherry Bay. With a commitment to sustainability, these destinations blend eco-friendly practices with exceptional MICE infrastructure, redefining how business and leisure events are hosted in India.

To spotlight these sustainable offerings and experiential meeting capabilities, GRT Hotels partnered with Air India to host an exclusive Familiarization (FAM) Trip for leading corporate clients from Delhi. Spanning Chennai, Mamallapuram, and Pondicherry, the immersive journey gave guests a first-hand look at each property's commitment to sustainable luxury, unique culinary identity, and readiness to host next-generation business events.

At Radisson Blu Hotel & Suites GRT Chennai, guests experience the power of biophilia-inspired design with the introduction of Biophilia Suites that enhance wellbeing and focus. The hotel offers state-of-the-art MICE facilities that incorporate responsible features like energy-efficient lighting, refillable amenities, and carbon offset programs.

Radisson Blu Resort Temple Bay Mamallapuram - nestled along the Bay of Bengal - boasts newly renovated luxury suites, alongside expansive indoor and outdoor venues ideal for hosting

conferences, destination weddings, and incentive meets. The resort is built to harmonize with nature, reducing environmental impact while delivering memorable experiences.

At Radisson Resort Pondicherry Bay, where culture meets sustainability, the hotel features suitable meeting spaces and celebrates Pondicherry's global recognition as Lonely Planet's second best Destination to Visit in 2025. The resort also introduces curated culinary experiences that spotlight Franco-Tamil cuisine, reflecting the region's rich heritage while emphasizing locally sourced, low-carbon menus.

Together, these three properties lead the way in GReaT Green Meetings initiative - where thoughtful design, local culture, and

environmental responsibility converge to offer conscious, impactful, and immersive meeting experiences.

"Sustainability is not a trend - it's a responsibility," said Mr. Vikram Cotah, CEO, GRT Hotels & Resorts. "It was an absolute pleasure to host our esteemed corporate guests across our properties in Chennai, Mamallapuram, and Pondicherry - showcasing our diverse choice of venues, excellent air connectivity, and destinations rich in culture and character. It was also an opportunity to demonstrate how sustainability and hospitality can truly go hand in hand. These immersive experiences reaffirm our belief that the future of travel and meetings lies in conscious, meaningful choices."



VANIITHA JAIN UNVEILS REVELRY DISTILLERY IN GOA AND VANAHA, A 100 % NATURAL GIN

Vaniitha Jain, one of India's foremost voices in the premium and luxury alcohol space, widely recognized among the Top 10 Women of Wine in India and internationally celebrated as an authority on wines and spirits has announced the launch of Revelry Distillery, a craft-driven distillery in Sattari India, that is committed to creating small-batch, world-class spirits that honour depth, origin and detail.

Located in the lush Sattari region of North Goa, Revelry Distillery is purpose-built to nurture small-batch spirits that honour terroir, sustainability

and precision. Designed with a global sensibility and equipped with state-of-the-art distillation technology, Revelry Distillery is more than a facility, it is a creative sanctuary where botanicals meet science and intuition meets intention. With a strong focus on scalability (approx a million bottles annually), the distillery is equipped with cutting-edge infrastructure, including a dedicated R&D lab and a meticulous spirits making system. The distillery houses a 5 step process for the creation of its artisanal gin namely, Botanical Maceration, Copper Pot Distillation, Vapour Infusion, Cold

**The first offering ushers in a new wave of Indian craft spirits
with Vanaha Gin and India's first 5 step Distilled Gin,
Forest to Bottle Gin, Crafted from 24 Handpicked Botanicals,
100 % Natural Gin**



Vacuum Distillation and Staging. Housing a customized Hagyo pot still from Hungary, it offers precision for exceptional flavour consistency & scalability. One of the very few distilleries in the world using the 3 techniques – Copper Pot distillation, Vapor Infusion and Cold Vacuum distillation in the production process, it is elevated by cutting-edge technologies that allow real-time monitoring and data-driven decision-making, using technology to craft the best.

From copper stills calibrated for gentle extraction to bespoke aging and blending processes, every detail has been curated to enable the creation of spirits with soul.

“Revelry is built on a foundation of authenticity, storytelling and meticulous craftsmanship, paving the way for India to establish itself as a key contender in the premium global spirits

market.” says Vaniitha Jain, Founder & Chief Evangelist of Revelry Distillery.

At the heart of this new venture lies its debut creation - Vanaha Gin. Inspired by the tranquility and biodiversity of Indian forests, Vanaha (Vana = forest; Aha = epiphany) is a Sipping Gin that seamlessly combines bold character with nuanced depth and forest-born elegance.

Distilled from the Forest, Made for the World, Vanaha is a 100 % natural gin with no artificial flavors , it embodies the essence of the forest and is a layered, expressive spirit that celebrates India’s rich natural landscape while catering to the tastes of the modern connoisseur who values moments of sophistication - whether in a gathering or solo.

Vanaha is a unique ‘Forest to Bottle’ gin, crafting a distinct identity that resonates with consumers by combining elements of heritage, rush



quality, and unique flavour profiles to create a memorable and aspirational presence in the market.

Crafted with deep respect for nature, Vanaha holds the rhythm of the forest – rich, layered and alive. It features a rare blend of 24 handpicked botanicals, including Deodar Wood, Patchouli, Cacao Nibs, Palash Flowers, Pine Tips, Assam Lemons, Wild Berries, Sikkim Mandarin, Orris Root, Angelica Root, and Juniper Berries. The botanicals are carefully selected for their purity, provenance, and contribution to the gin's Earthy, Woody and Aromatic profile. With no artificial flavors or additives, Vanaha is natural, distilled to its purest essence.

Elevated by Cold Vacuum Distillation – the first of its kind in India – this technique ensures the preservation of delicate botanical notes, allowing Vanaha to stand out in aroma, flavour, and finish. By combining three unique production methods, the result is a complex, smooth, and layered gin with floral, earthy, woody, and subtly spiced notes. It is best enjoyed as a neat pour with ice or in cocktails, offering a versatile experience for connoisseurs who value ritual, not rush.

Designed for discerning gin drinkers and collectors, Vanaha appeals to connoisseurs of craft spirits who appreciate depth and nuance, and to those who seek ritual, stillness, and sophistication in their drinking experience. It also resonates with global, evolved Indian consumers seeking premium, terroir-driven Indian spirits that reflect both provenance and purpose.

"With Vanaha, we are not just launching a gin – we hope to usher in a quiet revolution in Indian spirits: where provenance meets purity, craftsmanship meets consciousness, and indulgence meets intention. We wanted to create a spirit that speaks to the modern connoisseur – someone who seeks depth, not dazzle; ritual, not rush. At its core, Vanaha is a celebration of India – its richness, its roots, and its rising global presence. Our vision is to build a world-class gin that proudly embodies the Make in India spirit, and stands shoulder to shoulder with the finest international brands," says Vaniitha.

Vanaha arrives at a pivotal time for India's spirits market. The Indian gin market is estimated at \$1,789.8 million in 2025 and is expected to reach \$2,952 million by 2032, with a CAGR of 7.4%. The premium

gin segment alone is expected to expand from 20% to 45% of the total gin market – driven by an emerging audience that values authenticity, qualitative experiences, craftsmanship, and purposeful indulgence.

"With Revelry, we're building more than a brand – we're crafting a platform for Indian excellence in spirits. The focus is on quality, authenticity and global readiness. We believe India deserves its place on the map of world-class craft distillation," adds Navvin Jain, Director, Revelry Distillery.

Vanaha officially launched on 16th May 2025 in Goa, the heartland of its inspiration and origin. Following its debut at Goa, the gin will gradually roll out across key metro markets beginning with Karnataka. Priced at INR ₹2400 for a 750ml bottle at Goa, Vanaha is presented in exquisitely crafted glass bottles, each adorned with illustrated labels that reflect the spirit's profound connection to nature. The bottle's distinctive silhouette, cloaked in deep

forest-green hues, conjures the mystique of a rare botanical elixir. At the heart of the design lies the Woodpecker, embossed within the seal – an evocative and rare symbol of the vitality of India's forests, and a tribute to Vanaha's commitment to craftsmanship and artisanal distillation.

From the iridescent green of the bottle to the copper foiling, embossed detailing, and raised textures, every element of the packaging is as refined and intentional as the gin within – an invitation to indulge in a truly immersive forest-to-bottle experience.

Vanaha Gin is not just a product; it is a movement. It invites you to savour and experience gin as a form of poetic self-expression, and a portrayal of refined taste. With its earthy woody aromatic signature and depth in every sip, Vanaha is set to become a collectible for aficionados and a staple at refined celebrations around the world.





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TOURISM MALAYSIA FLY & RIDE CYCLE EVENT 2025

Cross - Border Cycling Adventure Concludes with Roaring Success

The inaugural Fly & Ride Cycle Event 2025 Cross Border Cycling Adventure: Malaysia & Thailand Edition, a groundbreaking cross-border cycling expedition, concluded with resounding success on May 23, 2025. Organized by Dayasakti Travel & Tours Sdn Bhd and Tourism Malaysia Chennai, and supported by Just Buy Cycles, the event brought together 30 passionate cyclists from South India for an exhilarating 200-kilometer journey through the picturesque landscapes of Malaysia and Thailand.

Held under the banner of Visit Malaysia Year 2026 (VMY 2026), the event was spearheaded by Mr. Hishamuddin Mustafa, Director of Tourism Malaysia Chennai (South India & Sri Lanka), and Dato' Chandran Suppiah, Director of Dayasakti Travel & Tours. Participants experienced a seamless fusion of adventure, culture, and camaraderie, forging new connections while traversing stunning locales.

The cycling odyssey began with a 20 kilometer heritage ride in Penang, allowing cyclists to explore the city's rich

cultural landmarks before a ferry ride to the mainland. The journey then continued into Thailand, with scenic coastal rides in Dannok, Songkhla, and Hatyai, where participants were met with warm local hospitality. A highlight of the event was the cross-border ride from Hatyai to Padang Besar, showcasing the seamless integration of tourism efforts between the two nations as cyclists pedaled into Arau, Kangar, before continuing by train to Ipoh. The expedition culminated with captivating city rides through Ipoh and Kuala Lumpur,



a visit to the iconic Batu Caves, and a memorable cultural dinner at Saloma Bistro set against the backdrop of the majestic KLCC Twin Towers.

The success of this ambitious event was a testament to the collaborative spirit of its key partners. Penang Global Tourism hosted a delightful lunch and coordinated the Penang leg, while KTM Berhad provided picturesque train rides from Butterworth to Ipoh, adding a unique dimension to the journey. Amazing Thailand extended crucial support for the Thai segment, ensuring a smooth cross-border experience. Furthermore, Transvel provided essential bicycle transport and mechanical support, emphasizing the event's commitment to sustainable and eco-friendly travel.

Dato' Chandran Suppiah remarked, "The Fly & Ride Cycle Event 2025 was not just a cycling adventure but a celebration of friendship, culture, and active living. The enthusiasm of the participants was truly inspiring." Mr. Hishamuddin Mustafa added, "This event beautifully showcased Malaysia's appeal as a cycling and eco-tourism destination while fostering international cooperation. It's a significant



milestone as we prepare for Visit Malaysia Year 2026. This is the first time a Fly & Ride package tour to Malaysia has ever been organised, promoting the beautiful scenery of Malaysia to avid cyclists from India."

Participants universally lauded the event as a unique and unforgettable experience,

seamlessly blending the thrill of cycling with the joy of cultural exploration. The Fly & Ride Cycle Event 2025 stands as a powerful example of how tourism can build bridges between nations and communities, marking a shining testament to the growing ties between Malaysia, Thailand, and India.



SAUDI ARABIA LAUNCHES TOURISE PLATFORM TO STEER GLOBAL TOURISM'S NEXT ERA

**TOURISE Summit, scheduled to take place in Riyadh
from November 11 to 13, 2025**

In a significant move to shape the future of international travel, Saudi Arabia has officially launched TOURISE, a landmark global platform designed to chart a new course for the tourism industry over the next 50 years. Unveiled by the Kingdom's Minister of Tourism, His Excellency Ahmed Al-Khateeb, the initiative aims to unite leaders from the public and private sectors

to foster innovation, drive investment, and build a more sustainable and resilient travel ecosystem.

Breaking new ground, TOURISE is positioned as the first global platform to bridge the gap between decision-makers in tourism, technology, investment, and sustainability. More than a single event, it is structured for continuous, year-round

impact through digital collaboration, specialized working groups, and cross-sector partnerships focused on long-term industry transformation. This sustained effort will include the development of influential white papers and global indices in collaboration with leading international organizations, setting new benchmarks for the sector.



The initiative's centerpiece will be the inaugural, invite-only TOURISE Summit, scheduled to take place in Riyadh from November 11 to 13, 2025. The summit's agenda will tackle critical areas, exploring the future of AI-powered tourism, disruptive investment models, the evolution of the travel experience, and how tourism can better serve people, the planet, and progress. A dedicated Innovation Zone will also showcase breakthrough solutions from a range of enterprises, from agile SMEs to large corporations.

The launch comes at a crucial time for the industry. According to the World Travel and Tourism Council (WTTTC), the sector is on a strong recovery path, projected to contribute a record \$11.7 trillion to the global economy this year. However, challenges such as shifting market dynamics and evolving traveler expectations require strategic navigation to maintain this momentum. TOURISE is designed to provide that vital support.

"Tourism is one of the most dynamic, connective forces in the world's economy, supporting one in ten jobs globally," stated His Excellency Ahmed Al-Khateeb, who also serves as Chairman of TOURISE. "But as the world evolves, the sector must too. Whether adapting to technological disruption and changing traveler

expectations, to addressing the urgent calls for sustainability and a more equitable approach to travel, TOURISE will be the much-needed platform to shape the future of tourism."

The platform's strategic direction is guided by a high-powered advisory board of global experts, chaired by His Excellency. Members include Julia Simpson, President & CEO of the World Travel & Tourism Council; Luis Maroto, CEO of Amadeus; and Stephane Lefebvre, President of Cirque du Soleil Entertainment Group, among other influential figures from across the travel and entertainment landscape.

"For this industry to evolve and reach its full potential, public-private sector collaboration is critical," commented Julia Simpson, who joined the Minister for the virtual launch. "Together, we can address the challenges of today while co-creating a sustainable and innovative future for tomorrow."

A key component of the platform is the TOURISE Awards, a recognition program created to celebrate destinations demonstrating excellence. The awards will spotlight outstanding achievements in areas such as sustainability, digital transformation, inclusive tourism, and cultural preservation, with winners to be announced on the opening night of the



November summit.

This initiative builds on Saudi Arabia's rapidly growing influence in the global tourism landscape. Having achieved its Vision 2030 goal of welcoming 100 million visitors seven years ahead of schedule in 2024, the Kingdom's tourism sector now contributes nearly 5% to its national GDP. By establishing TOURISE with global partners, Saudi Arabia is leveraging its success to foster worldwide progress and growth in the travel industry.



INDIAN OCEAN DIVERS ASSO. CONVENES SUCCESSFUL OCEAN SUMMIT IN COLOMBO

Jury Heads for Final Deliberations

The Indian Ocean Divers Association (IODA), in partnership with the Chamber of Marine Industries Sri Lanka (CMISL) and with the backing of the Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA), recently hosted a highly successful IODA Ocean Summit at the Cinnamon Grand in Colombo. The event brought together diving industry professionals from India, Maldives, and Sri Lanka to foster collaboration and promote sustainable marine tourism.

Call for Regional Collaboration and Sustainable Practices

Mr. Prahlad Kakar, President of IODA, delivered a compelling keynote address,

emphasizing the critical need for collaborative efforts to build a stronger and more sustainable diving industry across the Indian Ocean region. He underscored the immense value of regional cooperation in unlocking the full potential of marine tourism while prioritizing environmental stewardship. Kakar highlighted Sri Lanka's unique position, boasting year-round diving opportunities, rich heritage, and delicious cuisine, expressing optimism that the island nation could become a regional diving hub.

"This inaugural conference in Sri Lanka is historic for many reasons," stated Mr. Kakar. "One is because of the agenda of

what we are trying to do: to gather people who are like-minded, who are ocean lovers and have stakes in the ocean."

Exploring New Horizons in Marine Tourism

The summit also featured a fascinating presentation by Mr. Anees Adenwala, Vice President of IODA, who shared his extensive experience in underwater filming for Bollywood, offering unique insights into the creative intersection of film and marine exploration.

Throughout the event, dynamic panel discussions, targeted networking sessions, and active engagement from key stakeholders across the travel and diving



SATA 2025 EVALUATIONS CONCLUDE ACROSS SOUTH ASIA

Jury Heads for Final Deliberations



The South Asian Travel Awards (SATA) 2025 has wrapped up its extensive evaluation process across the region, with the multinational jury now progressing rapidly to finalize the winners. This year's rigorous assessments commenced in

Colombo, with subsequent dedicated sessions held in Bengaluru and New Delhi (India), Kathmandu (Nepal), Paro (Bhutan), Dhaka (Bangladesh), and Malé (Maldives). The final evaluation sessions were held in the Maldives, bringing the comprehensive

review to a close.

SATA continues to stand out as the only travel award in the region that conducts in-person evaluations across South Asia. This unique approach provides nominees in eight key cities the invaluable opportunity to directly present their entries to the esteemed panel. The jury diligently assesses and scores each nomination, ensuring that only the most deserving in South Asian hospitality receive recognition. Importantly, there are no charges for participation or the evaluation process, maintaining a transparent and accessible platform for the industry.

The highly anticipated 9th edition of the prestigious SATA Gala is scheduled to take place in Sri Lanka in September 2025. It is at this grand event that the winners, celebrating excellence in the South Asian travel and hospitality industry will be officially announced.

sectors facilitated meaningful dialogue. These interactions are expected to pave the way for future cross-border partnerships and innovations within the marine tourism industry.

Sri Lanka's Untapped Marine Tourism Potential

Discussions at the summit particularly focused on Sri Lanka's significant, yet largely untapped, potential for marine tourism. With an impressive 167 known shipwrecks submerged in its surrounding waters, many dating back to the world wars, the island presents a unique offering for dive tourism. Traditionally, Sri Lanka's tourism appeal has centered on beaches, wildlife, culture, and nature. However, conference participants strongly suggested that shipwrecks and underwater exploration could become a pivotal component of the nation's future tourism strategy.

Mr. Prasad Jayasuriya, Director of Tourism Planning at the SLTDA, acknowledged the

growing interest in ocean-related tourism, especially given that Sri Lanka's maritime area is twice the size of its landmass. He stressed the importance of developing ocean tourism strategically, with diving at its core, leveraging the country's extensive marine resources. The concept of intentionally sinking decommissioned ships to create new dive sites, complementing existing wrecks, was also explored.

Mr. Kakar, also a co-founder of ReefWatch Marine Conservation and an experienced scuba diver, described the summit as a vital platform for all stakeholders in marine environments, including hoteliers, fishing communities, and divers. He proposed that establishing standards in dive tourism and underwater activities could "be the start of a worldwide movement." Kakar emphasized the critical importance of preserving ocean ecosystems, advocating for the protection of shipwrecks—some of which may contain historical artifacts—from vandalism and

theft. He believes promoting these wrecks through tourism can attract global interest, particularly from those fascinated by wartime history.

Mr. Anees Adenwala, Vice President of IODA and a pioneer in India's outbound scuba diving and underwater filming industry, highlighted divers' natural inclination to explore underwater environments, stressing their crucial role in protecting marine ecosystems.

The summit concluded with a unanimous call for the development of clear regulations and responsible practices in marine tourism. This collective commitment aims to ensure that ocean resources are preserved while simultaneously fostering sustainable growth in the tourism sector.

The IODA Ocean Summit was generously supported by MistEO, Sail Lanka, Maldives Holiday Collections, Medium Events, and Floating Asia.

SRI LANKA MICE EXPO 2025: SHOWCASING SRI LANKA AS A PREMIER MICE DESTINATION

The expo will take place in Colombo from Sept 22- 26, 2025

Sri Lanka is gearing up to host the highly anticipated SL-MICE Expo 2025, a landmark event set to solidify the island nation's position as a premier destination for Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions (MICE). Organized by the Sri Lanka Convention Bureau (SLCB), the expo will take place in Colombo from September 22nd to 26th, 2025.

Building on the success of four previous editions since 2021, the SL-MICE Expo has become a cornerstone of Sri Lanka's MICE calendar. What began as virtual gatherings has evolved into vibrant physical events, consistently attracting a diverse array of

international and local stakeholders and showcasing Sri Lanka's unique potential in the global MICE landscape.

SL-MICE Expo 2025: A New Chapter for Sri Lanka's MICE Tourism

Aligned with the SLCB's mandate, the 2025 expo promises to be a pivotal moment for Sri Lanka's MICE industry. It will serve as an exceptional platform for both local and international MICE sector players to display their products, services, and innovations. The event is poised to be a dynamic marketplace, fostering significant business growth, crucial networking, and valuable collaborations among MICE professionals worldwide.

Highlights of SL-MICE Expo 2025 will include:

A five-day immersive program: This comprehensive agenda will feature an opening plenary session, a dynamic business forum designed to spark insightful discussions, and tailored B2B meetings to facilitate direct connections and potential partnerships.

A splendid themed gala dinner: This exclusive event will offer unparalleled networking opportunities, seamlessly blending business with unique "Bleisure" (business + leisure) experiences.

An exclusive familiarization tour: Attendees will have the chance to embark on a captivating tour to the scenic regions of Kandy and Nuwara Eliya, providing a firsthand experience of Sri Lanka's rich cultural heritage and breathtaking natural beauty.

Register Now to Be a Fully Hosted Buyer!

The Sri Lanka Convention Bureau extends a special invitation to buyers and media representatives from key international markets. These include India, China, Pakistan, Germany, Russia, France, UK, Turkey, Spain, UAE, Bangladesh, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, Malaysia, Japan, Singapore, and Iran.

"Don't miss this chance to explore Sri Lanka's thriving MICE industry and forge valuable partnerships!" encourages the SLCB. Interested parties are urged to register today at www.srilankamiceexpo.com to secure their spot as a fully hosted buyer.

For further information, please contact the Sri Lanka Convention Bureau via call or WhatsApp at +94 773 416 665 or +94 777 257103.

THOMAS COOK INDIA & MUTHOOT GROUP PARTNER TO EXPAND FOREX CARD REACH

The partnership brings Thomas Cook's innovative forex solutions closer to a wider customer base offering distinct advantages

Thomas Cook (India) Limited, a leading omnichannel forex services provider, has announced a strategic collaboration with Muthoot Forex, the foreign exchange division of the Muthoot Group. This partnership aims to significantly expand the distribution of Thomas Cook's popular Borderless Travel and Study Buddy Cards across India. Through this alliance, both prepaid forex cards will now be readily available across Muthoot Group's vast network of over 7,000 branches nationwide, including 43 dedicated full-fledged forex branches. This extensive reach covers not only major metropolitan areas but also mini-metros and crucial Tier 2-4 source markets, making international travel and overseas education financial solutions more accessible than ever before.

The partnership brings Thomas Cook's innovative forex solutions closer to a wider customer base, offering distinct advantages for different traveler segments. The Borderless Travel Card, designed for outbound leisure travelers, offers a smart, secure, and convenient way to manage international transactions. It supports up to 12 global currencies for seamless transactions worldwide and is accepted at over 70 million Mastercard and Visa merchant establishments in more than 200 countries. Users benefit from free emergency cash assistance and card replacement for lost or stolen cards, a complimentary International global SIM card, embedded chip & PIN security, and a complimentary insurance cover up to 7.5 lakh (terms and conditions apply). Travel perks include complimentary airport meet & greet, free lounge access, and porter services at select international airports in India (terms and conditions apply), plus an exclusive 25% discount on select attractions and unique experiences

(terms and conditions apply). Customers can also earn 1,000 Thomas Cook Edge Reward Points when loading USD 1,000 (or equivalent) and up to 500 points on card spend, redeemable for holidays, flights, and hotels from Thomas Cook India. The card also allows free ATM withdrawals (terms and conditions apply), features an eco-friendly design crafted from recycled plastic, and offers 24x7 customer support via call center, email, and web support on thomascook.in.

Specifically curated for Indian students pursuing education abroad, the Study Buddy Card offers comprehensive support. It includes a free International Student Identity Card (ISIC), a free global SIM Card, and convenient ATM access with one free ATM withdrawal per month and surcharge-free withdrawals at Allpoint ATMs in the USA, Canada, Mexico, UK, and Australia. The card boasts zero markup on transactions made in its base currency, provides comprehensive Fraud Protection Insurance (terms and conditions apply), and offers 24x7 customer support. Students also benefit from free emergency cash assistance, free card replacement on loss

of card, free lounge access at International Airports in India (terms and conditions apply), and earn KrisFlyer miles on every forex purchase.

Mr. Deepesh Varma, Executive Vice President-Foreign Exchange, Thomas Cook (India) Limited, commented on the collaboration: "At Thomas Cook India, we are committed to making our forex card solutions smooth, seamless, and rewarding for our customers. Our alliance with The Muthoot Group leverages our powerful synergies-combining our expertise in travel and foreign exchange with Muthoot's extensive network across India's Tier 1-4 source markets. Through this partnership, we aim to bring our Borderless Travel and Study Buddy cards closer to consumers across India's metros and regional markets, making international travel and study abroad even more convenient and accessible." This strategic alliance is expected to significantly enhance the accessibility of secure and convenient foreign exchange solutions for a wide range of Indian consumers embarking on international journeys, whether for leisure, business, or education.



ACCOR APPOINTS CYRUS MADAN AS DIRECTOR OF DEVELOPMENT, INDIA & SOUTH ASIA



Accor, a prominent international Hotel brand has announced the appointment of Mr. Cyrus Madan as Director of Development, India & South

Asia. With nearly three decades of rich experience across hospitality management and hotel business development, Cyrus brings his deep understanding of the industry and a strategic vision to his new role.

Cyrus has held leadership positions across renowned hospitality brands including Lemon Tree Hotels and Atmosphere Hospitality, and began his professional journey with the Taj in New Delhi. An alumnus of the Welcome Group Graduate School of Hotel Administration, his expertise in strategy & business development, client relationship and deep understanding of complex market dynamics will play a vital role in driving Accor's growth in the region.

Aniruddh Kumar, Vice-President of

Development India & South Asia at Accor, commented on the appointment, "We are pleased to welcome Cyrus Madan to Accor. His extensive experience, deep knowledge of the industry will be instrumental for the expansion, partnerships, and asset growth in India and South Asia."

Commenting on his appointment, Cyrus Madan said, "I am delighted to join Accor and be a part of its dynamic team. I look forward to contributing to the development initiatives and creating long-term value as the group continues to strengthen its presence across India and South Asia."

Cyrus's appointment reinforces Accor's commitment to building a robust leadership team as the group continues to expand its presence and partnerships across the region.

EROS HOTEL NEW DELHI APPOINTS MEENAKSHI CHATTERJEE AS MARKETING, PR & COM. MANAGER

Eros Hotel Nehru Place in New Delhi, the luxury business hotel nestled in the heart of the capital, has announced the appointment of Ms. Meenakshi Chatterjee as Marketing, PR and Communication Manager.

Bringing over 10 years of experience in public relations, brand strategy, and integrated communications, Meenakshi will lead the development and execution of innovative public relations, marketing campaigns, and external communications. With a sharp understanding of consumer behaviour, evolving market dynamics, and effective storytelling, she will also take care of social media management to amplify the hotel's positioning in a competitive hospitality landscape.

Prior to this, Meenakshi has worked with Karma Lakelands, Pullman and Novotel, The Lalit Suri Hospitality Group and The Leela Ambience Gurugram. Her last assignment was with Rasandik Engineering Industries as Marketing Manager. Her role at Eros Hotel will involve driving offline and

online marketing strategies for increased brand visibility, and fostering strategic partnerships that enhance the hotel's reputation.

On her appointment, Mr. Davinder Juj, General Manager of Eros Hotel New Delhi, said, "Meenakshi is an energetic marketing professional with a good track record of working with renowned hospitality brands. I think that her experience and hands-on approach make her a great fit for our team. I look forward to seeing her translate her vision into impactful campaigns that strengthen the hotel."

Sharing her excitement, Meenakshi commented, "I'm truly grateful to be part of such a prestigious brand. Eros Hotel has a rich legacy and I look forward to contributing to its continued growth through creative, data-driven, and customer-focused marketing strategies."

Beyond her professional achievements, Meenakshi likes to write - an extension of her storytelling abilities and creative spirit, which she brings into her work with

authenticity and enthusiasm.

With this appointment, Eros Hotel continues its focus on building a team of forward-thinking professionals committed to excellence and innovation in hospitality.



LEMON TREE HOTELS APPOINTS MR. VISHVAPREET SINGH CHEEMA AS PRESIDENT & NIKET SOOD AS VP-COMMERCIAL STRATEGY

Lemon Tree Hotels has announced two senior leadership appointments to support the group's continued growth. Vishvapreet Singh Cheema has taken over as the new President, while Niket Sood has joined as Vice President - Commercial Strategy.

Lemon Tree Hotels Limited has informed the Mumbai stock Exchange regarding the appointment of Mr. Vishvapreet Singh Cheema as President (Senior Management Personnel) of the company w.e.f. Jun 09, 2025.

Cheema brings with him 30 years of experience in the hospitality industry. He has worked with global hotel brands including InterContinental, Marriott, and Radisson. Most recently, he headed operations for IHG Hotels in South West Asia, covering markets such as India, Nepal, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka. He began his career at Oberoi Hotels & Resorts and has held a variety of senior roles throughout his



journey.

Sood has close to 20 years of experience with international hospitality brands like Accor and Marriott International. Before



joining Lemon Tree Hotels, he led the strategy for Accor South Asia, where he focussed on driving market share growth and commercial performance.

SHIJU DEVASSY PROMOTED TO DIRECTOR OF ENGINEERING FOR COURTYARD BY MARRIOTT KOCHI AIRPORT AND PORT MUZIRIS, A TRIBUTE PORTFOLIO HOTEL, KOCHI.

The Courtyard by Marriott Kochi Airport and Port Muziris, a Tribute Portfolio Hotel, Kochi has announced the promotion of Mr. Shiju Devassy as the Director of Engineering. A valued member of the Marriott International family for over 12 years, Mr. Shiju has consistently showcased exemplary leadership, technical acumen, and an unwavering commitment to excellence. His instrumental role in elevating engineering standards, leading the pre-opening of Port Muziris, and being recognized as the Best Engineer in South Asia in 2018 are testaments to his

outstanding contributions.

In his new role, we are confident that Mr. Shiju will continue to drive innovation and operational excellence across both properties.

"Shiju's journey is a reflection of what consistent dedication and quiet leadership can achieve. This promotion is both well-earned and well-deserved," said Narayan Tharoor, General Manager.

"I'm truly honored by this opportunity and look forward to contributing further to the growth and success of both hotels," said Mr. Shiju Devassy.



MAHINDRA GROUP APPOINTS ASHA KHARGA AS CHIEF CUSTOMER OFFICER AT MAHINDRA HOLIDAYS & RESORTS INDIA LTD.



The Mahindra Group announced the appointment of Ms Asha Kharga, currently serving as the Chief Customer Officer of Mahindra Group, as Chief Customer Officer of Mahindra Holidays & Resorts India Ltd. (MHRIL), effective July 1, 2025. Mahindra Holidays creates wonderful memories for its members at our resorts. It is now poised to transform the overall customer experience,

broaden its product offerings and embark on a journey of significant growth.

Asha brings over 28 years of rich experience in transforming customer-centric brands into premium offerings across multiple industries. Asha has been recognized for her strategic acumen, creative excellence, and ability to harness consumer insights. Her leadership will be instrumental in spearheading MHRIL's brand transformation, guest experience innovation, and marketing strategy as the company doubles its resort footprint and elevates its offerings to cater to the evolving needs of leisure travellers.

Commenting on the development, Dr. Anish Shah, Group CEO & MD, Mahindra Group, said, "Asha's expertise will be key to leveraging the potential of Mahindra Holidays, as we seek to transform and significantly grow the business. Her strength in aligning brand vision with customer experiences will be valuable for the business. This move is consistent with

the Group's philosophy to place strong leaders in areas of meaningful value creation."

Mr. Manoj Bhat, MD & CEO, MHRIL, added, "We are delighted to welcome Asha to our leadership team. We have ambitious plans as we expand our resort footprint to 10,000 keys by 2030. Our focus is on premium offerings, and we wanted a seasoned leader with the expertise to align brand vision with exceptional experiences. Her appointment will accelerate building a business that meets the changing needs of leisure travellers".

Expressing her enthusiasm for the role, Asha Kharga said, "I'm eager to contribute to the next chapter by focusing on the emotional, experiential, and cultural aspects that define our hospitality offerings. As the business grows, our greatest differentiator will not just be our presence, but how we make people feel when they stay with us. I look forward to working together with the incredible team at MHRIL."

TAMARIND GLOBAL APPOINTS VINEET SETHI AS CHIEF BUSINESS OFFICER – GURGAON



Tamarind Global, one of India's leading Destination and Event Management Companies, is pleased to welcome Vineet Sethi as Chief Business Officer – Gurgaon. With nearly three decades of rich experience in the Travel and Tourism

industry, Vineet brings with him a wealth of strategic insight, transformational leadership, and a passion for innovation.

An alumnus of both the Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad and the Indian School of Business, Vineet has held key leadership roles across several premier travel organizations, where he has driven significant growth and business innovation. His deep-rooted industry knowledge and expertise in scaling businesses position him as a vital asset to the Tamarind Global leadership team.

In his new role, Vineet will lead growth strategies across North India, driving expansion across Tamarind Global's Corporate Travel, MICE, and Luxury Leisure verticals. He will also focus on strengthening strategic alliances to help increase the brand's market penetration.

Louis D'Souza, Managing Partner, Tamarind Global, shared: "We are thrilled

to have Vineet onboard! His exceptional industry background and energetic approach align perfectly with our vision of innovation and expansion. We're confident his leadership will open exciting new business avenues while enhancing operational efficiency across the region."

Vineet Sethi commented: "I am delighted to join Tamarind Global, a brand synonymous with excellence and customer delight. I look forward to contributing to its ongoing success by nurturing partnerships, exploring new market opportunities, and deepening our footprint in this dynamic region."

With this key appointment, Tamarind Global reinforces its commitment to building a future-ready leadership team delivering seamless, memorable experiences across corporate and personal travel, destination weddings, events, and beyond.

CHEF SHIIV PARVESH APPOINTED AS DIRECTOR OF CULINARY AT NOVOTEL HYDERABAD CON. CENTRE & HYDERABAD INTERNATIONAL CONVENTION CENTRE

Novotel Hyderabad Convention Centre and Hyderabad International Convention Centre have announced the appointment of Chef Shiiv Parvesh as their Director of Culinary, marking a significant milestone in the culinary landscape of this multi-dimensional lifestyle complex. With over 20 years of unparalleled expertise, Chef Shiiv Parvesh is set to bring his visionary approach to gastronomy to the heart of this renowned establishment.

A luminary in the culinary realm, Chef Shiiv Parvesh's journey began with a profound inspiration from the flavors of his mother's kitchen, leading him to pursue a postgraduate degree in kitchen management from the prestigious Oberoi Centre of Learning and Development (OCLD). His illustrious career has seen him honing his craft at renowned hospitality brands such as Oberoi, Hyatt, and the Marriott Group of Hotels, where he not only mastered culinary arts but also left an indelible mark on the global stage.

Chef Shiiv Parvesh's media presence is equally captivating, with interactive cooking shows and curated culinary events

that have garnered admiration worldwide. His new role at Novotel Hyderabad & HICC signifies a pivotal leadership position in guiding kitchen teams across various domains, from F&B outlets to orchestrating culinary experiences for MICE, events, and weddings.

Renowned for his continual innovation and passion for learning, Chef Shiiv Parvesh's culinary finesse has earned him numerous accolades, including the prestigious Best Regional Cuisine Award 2018 by the International Federation of Chefs Association (IFCA). Beyond his culinary expertise, he finds inspiration in travel, exploring diverse cultures, and connecting with nature.

Mr. Rubin Cherian, General Manager of Novotel Hyderabad Convention Centre and Hyderabad International Convention Centre, expressed his excitement about Chef Shiiv Parvesh's appointment, stating, "As the Director of Culinary at Novotel Hyderabad & HICC, Chef Shiiv Parvesh will undoubtedly elevate the gastronomic experience, leaving an indelible mark on the culinary landscape of Hyderabad."



In response, Chef Shiiv Parvesh expressed his honor to take on this role at Novotel Hyderabad Convention Centre & HICC, emphasizing his commitment to crafting memorable dining experiences for guests through creativity and innovation. He envisions each dish as an innovative masterpiece, promising an upscale culinary adventure for every dining moment.

Additionally, Chef Shiiv Parvesh also led the opening of 'Permit to Grill', a new restaurant concept at the hotel. By combining bold flavours with cutting-edge grilling methods, this exciting restaurant offers patrons an open-fire dining experience that values both regional and international influences.

SHERATON GRAND BANGALORE HOTEL AT BRIGADE GATEWAY APPOINTS SUNIL RAI AS EXECUTIVE SOUS CHEF



Sheraton Grand Bangalore Hotel at Brigade Gateway has announced the appointment of Mr. Sunil Rai as the new Executive Sous Chef. A seasoned culinary professional with over 20 years of experience in luxury hotels, event catering, and food consultancy, Sunil brings with him a deep passion for culinary excellence, team

leadership, and innovative dining concepts.

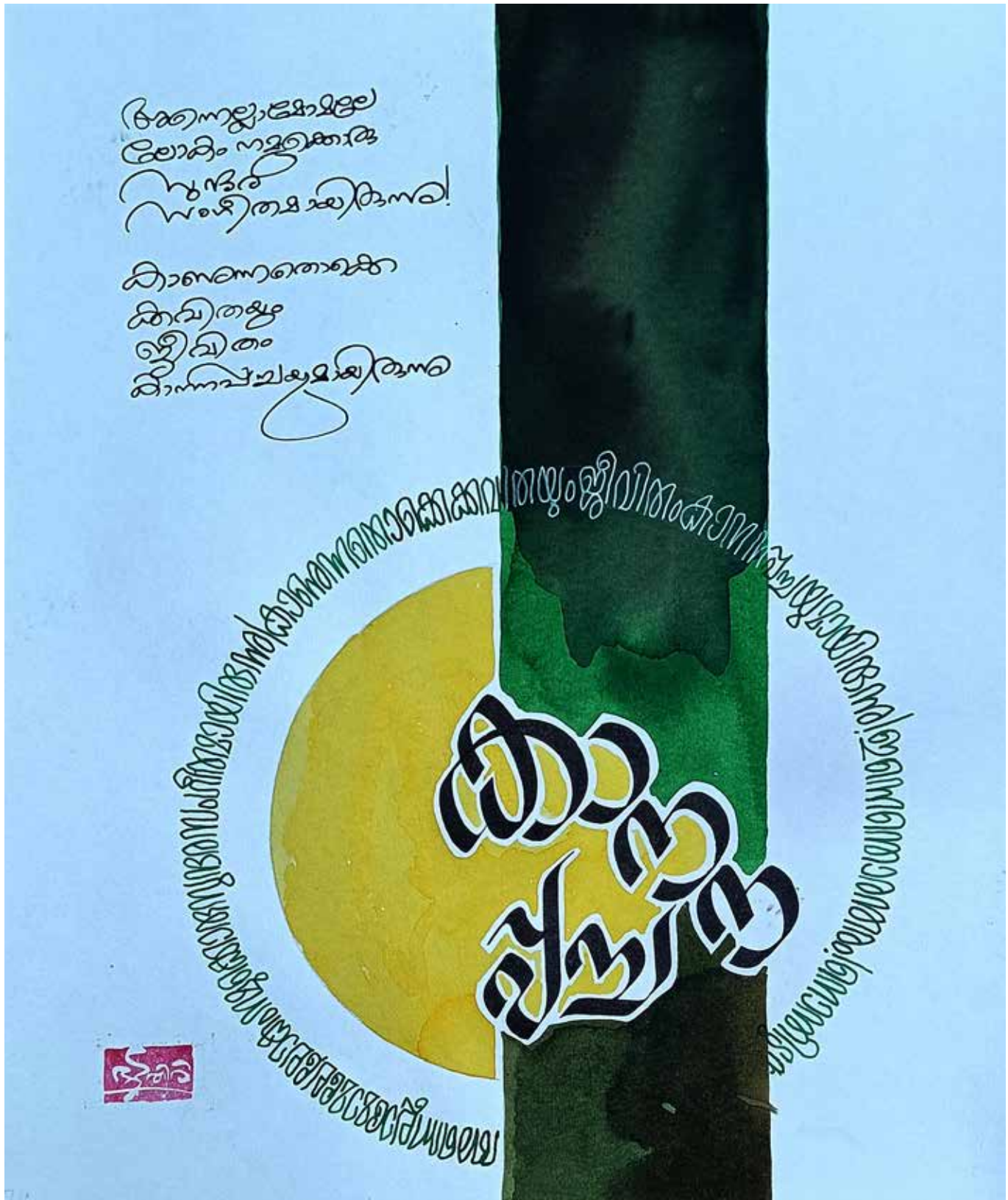
In his new role, Sunil will oversee the hotel's culinary operations, driving consistency in food quality, curating innovative menus, and delivering elevated dining experiences across all outlets and events.

Prior to joining Sheraton Grand Bangalore Hotel at Brigade Gateway, he served as Corporate Chef at Gwalia Group Pvt. Ltd., where he led operations across multiple kitchens and spearheaded the introduction of innovative food formats, vendor partnerships, and guest engagement strategies. He has also held key culinary positions at Grand Hyatt Goa, JW Marriott Bengaluru Prestige Golfshire Resort & Spa, Hyatt Regency Kolkata, and Hyatt Regency

Chandigarh.

A graduate in Hotel Management from IIAS College, Goa, Sunil's portfolio includes high-profile event catering, including international corporate gatherings and high-end weddings. He is known for bringing live cooking concepts to the forefront, focusing on flavour authenticity, cost efficiency, and sustainability.

"We are delighted to welcome Chef Sunil Rai to our team," said Ms. Sushma Khichar, General Manager, Sheraton Grand Bangalore Hotel at Brigade Gateway. "His vast experience in large-scale culinary operations and his forward-thinking approach to food presentation and guest satisfaction make him a valuable addition to our culinary leadership."



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- HACCP - Food Hygiene & Safety certification from **British Standard Institution** (ISO 22000).